

Madras High Court stays suspension of DVAC Inspector

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has stayed the operation of a suspension order passed against Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) Inspector of Police G. Vimala after arriving at a *prima facie* view that the suspension order appeared to be “motivated.”

Counter affidavit

Justice P.T. Asha stayed till July 9, 2026, the suspension order passed by the Deputy Director of DVAC on June 17, 2026, and granted time till the next date of hearing for the Deputy Director as well as the Director to file their counter affidavits to the Inspector’s writ petition.

FIR registered

On perusing the documents produced by the petitioner, the judge found that the suspension order appeared to have been issued for having registered a First Information Report against another Inspector of Police serving in the Anti-Vice squad of Greater Chennai police.

Observing that the FIR appeared to have been registered only with the approval of the superior officials in the DVAC, the judge wrote: “This court is of the *prima facie* view that the impugned (under challenge) suspension order is motivated. Therefore, it shall be stayed till July 9, 2026.”

Advanced sewage sludge treatment can increase biogas production: study

Sludge generated in Chennai Metrowater’s sewage treatment plants contained heavy metals in low concentrations, making it viable for reuse after treatment, says the Anna University study

WATER WATCH

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

While focus has largely remained on wastewater treatment, the reuse of sewage sludge is seldom optimised. In a recent study, Anna University has demonstrated that the adoption of advanced treatment technology in sewage treatment plants could increase biogas production by nearly 28% and be reused in various applications.

The study found that sewage sludge generated in Chennai Metrowater’s sewage treatment plants contained low concentrations of heavy metals, within international standards, making it viable for reuse after treatment.

However, researchers from Anna University noted that raw sludge showed significant microbial contamination, including that of salmonella. Pathogens were found to exceed prescribed standards in raw sludge samples, posing a major barrier to sludge reuse and necessitating additional treatment.

Given the constraints, including land scarcity and limited treatment infrastructure, sewage sludge



Daily load: Twenty STPs in Chennai treat 650 million litres of sewage a day and generate 94 tonnes of dry sludge. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

management and safe disposal are emerging as environmental challenges. Once pathogen risks are addressed, treated sludge could be used to support various applications, including land restoration, urban forestry, and soil rehabilitation programmes, according to the study.

Researchers from Anna University analysed sludge samples from 12 of Chennai Metrowater’s STPs over 18 months for the study funded by the Central Public Health and Environmental Engineering Organisation, Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

Chennai currently treats 650 million litres of sewage per day through 20 of its STPs, and generates 94 tonnes of dry sludge per day. Eleven of the STPs generate nearly 24,500 cubic metres of biogas.

S. Kanmani, principal investigator of the study and Head, Department of Civil Engineering and director-in-charge, Centre for Climate Change and Disaster Management, said it was imperative for the STPs to evolve beyond their conventional role of pollution control facilities and prioritise reuse of the treated sludge or reuse of biosolids. The study de-

monstrated the feasibility of adapting sustainable thermal-based sludge stabilisation and resource recovery technology to Chennai’s STPs. With suitable modifications, STPs can adopt it to increase biogas production and improve the use of biosolids, she said.

With the application of the technology, an STP could yield up to 31,365 cubic metres of biogas, which is nearly 28% higher than the current generation. Moreover, the treatment process also helped remove faecal coliform and significantly reduced salmonella in the sludge, enabling treated biosolids for better reuse, said the study published in the Environmental Monitoring and Assessment journal.

‘Cost-effective’

Saranya Kuppusamy, the study’s co-principal investigator and visiting professor, Department of Civil Engineering, Anna University, said the cost-effective technology would also help reduce the volume of sludge requiring disposal by about 60%.

Anna University is also exploring pilot projects with its industry partner - Larsen and Toubro - and scaling up technology for implementation across the State, Ms. Kanmani said.

Jharkhand workers stranded in T.N. after ammonia leak at firm

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

Forty-one migrant workers from Jharkhand, who were evacuated from St. Paul and Peter Seafood Export Firm at Periyapalayam in Tiruvallur district, after the ammonia leak that claimed 16 lives, remain stranded in Tamil Nadu without any assistance to return to their home State.

Officials in Tiruvallur district said there had been no response from the Jharkhand government despite repeated requests to facilitate the workers’ return.

On June 21, migrant workers from Assam, Jharkhand, and Odisha employed at the seafood processing unit were evacuated after the ammonia leak. More than 80 workers exposed to the toxic gas were admitted to hospitals. Sixteen workers – 13 from Odisha, two from Jharkhand, and one from Assam – died.

The surviving workers were accommodated at a marriage hall in Periyapalayam, where the Tamil Nadu government has been providing food, shelter, and medical assistance.

Officials from the Odisha and Assam governments visited the affected workers and coordinated with the Tiruvallur administration to arrange their transportation back home by train. However, 41 workers from Jharkhand continue to remain at the shelter in Periyapalayam, with no clarity on when they

will be able to return.

One of the stranded workers appealed to the Jharkhand government to intervene immediately. “Everyone wants to return home, but we are not being allowed to leave. The Jharkhand government should take note of our situation and provide us with immediate relief,” he said.

‘Severe mental stress’

Another video message from one of the workers said: “After the ammonia leak, we were shifted to this shelter. We have been here for several days. We are being provided food, but we are not allowed to go outside or leave. No one has informed us whether we will be sent home or what will happen next. Our identity documents are checked repeatedly, and we are under severe mental stress.”

A revenue official in Tiruvallur said representatives of the Odisha and Assam governments had personally visited the affected workers from their respective States and coordinated their return. “We extended all necessary assistance to facilitate their journey. However, 41 workers from Jharkhand are yet to be repatriated. We have sent emails and made phone calls to the Jharkhand authorities, but there has been no response so far. Until then, we will be providing them with shelter, food, and medical assistance while continuing efforts to arrange their return,” the official added.

State women’s commission seeks report on Tiruvallur ammonia leak

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu State Commission for Women (TNSCW) has ordered a comprehensive inquiry into the ammonia gas leak at a seafood processing unit in Tiruvallur district that has so far claimed the lives of 16 migrant workers and left several others critically injured.

Taking *suo motu* cognisance of the incident based on media reports, the commission directed the Tiruvallur Collector to submit a detailed report within four weeks. In its communication dated June 25, the commission said the victims were predominantly women migrant workers from Odisha and other States, who were not only employed at the factory but were also residing in the accommodation provided on the factory premises.

The commission asked the district administration to examine whether the factory possessed the required licences and approval to handle ammonia and whether it complied with labour safety, occupational health and statutory regulations.

The district administration was also asked to detail the legal action initiated against those responsible for the accident, the compensation and assistance provided to the victims and the families of the deceased.

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From Page One

M.R. Vijayabhaskar resigns as MLA

In a counter-affidavit filed before Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan, through Advocate-General Vijay Narayan, Assembly Secretary R. Santhi said a three-judge Bench of the Supreme Court, too, in *Shri-manth Balasaheb Patil vs Honourable Speaker of Karnataka* (2019) had held that the motive would be “irrelevant”.

The counter-affidavit was filed in response to two writ petitions filed by AIADMK whip Agri S.S. Krishnamurthy. The petitioner had challenged the Speaker's decision to accept the resignation of S. Jayakumar, P. Sathyabama, Maragatham Kumara-vel, and Esaki Subaya, who had been elected on AIADMK ticket.

‘It is voluntary and genuine’

Ms. Santhi said the Speaker had accepted the resignation because all the four MLAs had submitted their handwritten resignation letters in person. “The first respondent [the Speaker], upon receipt of the respective resignation letters and after interacting with the Members... and after such inquiry as he thought fit in the facts and circumstances, satisfied himself that the resignation was voluntary and genuine,” she added.

Further, there was no material or circumstance before the Speaker casting any doubt on the voluntariness or genuineness of the resignation letters. Therefore, the Speaker had accepted them in discharge of his constitutional function, the Assembly Secretary said. “It is denied that the acceptance was hasty, mechanical, illusory, *mala fide*, biased, colourable, or actuated by any extraneous or partisan consideration, as is baldly and irresponsibly alleged [by the writ petitioner]. The first respondent occupies a high constitutional office... and a presumption of regularity is attached to his official acts, which the petitioner has not even attempted to displace by any material particulars,” the counter-affidavit read.

The officer highlighted that Article 190(3)(b) of the Constitution empowers the Speaker to reject a resignation only if it is not genuine or voluntary. “The scheme of the provision is that acceptance is the norm; refusal is the exception,” she said, underlining that the Speaker also enjoys the discretion to determine the nature and extent of inquiry to be conducted before accepting the resignation.

Referring to the use of the words, ‘such inquiry as he thinks fit’, in the Article, Ms. Santhi said the language makes it clear that the Speaker need not necessarily conduct an elaborate or adversarial inquiry even in instances wherein the members tender their handwritten resignation letters in person.

The Assembly Secretary also argued that the writ petitioner had no enforceable legal right to compel the Speaker to reject the resignation letters just because the four MLAs were facing disqualification proceedings for having allegedly violated the AIADMK whip by voting in favour of a vote of confidence moved by the Chief Minister in the Assembly on May 13.

The officer made it clear that the acceptance of the resignation letters would not absolve the individuals concerned from the pending disqualification proceedings. Nevertheless, she said, the writ petitioner could not seek a direction to the Speaker to adjudicate the disqualification proceedings within a time frame to be fixed by the court.

After taking the counter-affidavit on file, the judges adjourned the hearing to July 13, since advocate S.R. Rajagopal, representing the writ petitioner, sought time to file a rejoinder.

Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin termed the resignation of Mr. M.R. Vijayabhaskar a betrayal of the people. He said the development exposed the extreme levels to which the ruling party’s “poaching politics” had escalated. “Continuously purchasing MLAs owing to lack of confidence in the alliance partners that helped to form the government is a massive betrayal of the people,” he said.

Stalin, Kanimozhi condemn arrest of DMK cadre for protesting against Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin and deputy general secretary Kanimozhi on Monday strongly condemned the denial of permission and the subsequent arrest of DMK student wing cadre who attempted to protest against Human Resources Management Minister D. Sarathkumar. The protests were triggered by a video, which showed the Minister performing actions that looked like preparations for snorting drugs, during an IPL match at the M.A. Chidambaram Cricket Stadium in Chennai.

“The arrest of DMK members protesting against a Minister, the registration of a case against former Minister Sivasankar for criticising the TVK ad-



The Chief Minister is desperately trying to safeguard a fake image by intimidating the Opposition and evading the media. This authoritarian approach will not last long

M.K. STALIN
DMK president

ministration, and the recent raid at former Minister E.V. Velu's residence all point to one thing: the Chief Minister [C. Joseph Vijay] is desperately trying to safeguard a fake image by intimidating the Opposition and evading the media. This authoritarian approach will not last long. The people will teach them a fitting lesson,” Mr. Stalin wrote in a post on X.



Ms. Kanimozhi questioned the democratic credentials of the ruling dispensation. “The TVK government, which calls itself a democratic force, is denying permission even for the opposition to hold peaceful protests. A proper investigation must be conducted against the accused Minister, and action should be taken,” she added.

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The resignation of the AIADMK's MLA from Karur, M.R. Vijayabhaskar, illustrates the fragile nature of the rebels' truce with party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami.

Mr. Vijayabhaskar, who held the portfolio of Transport during 2016-21, when Jayalalithaa, O. Panneerselvam, and Mr. Palaniswami were Chief Ministers, was among the 25 dissidents who sided with the Tamila-ga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government during the motion on vote of confidence moved by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in the Assembly on May 13, defying their party's whip.

However, two weeks later, he and 20 others returned to the fold of the faction led by Mr. Palaniswami, who had got the disqualification proceedings dropped against them by writing to Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar.

Since then, there has been, by and large, an eerie silence on the part of the dissidents.

‘Suppressing dissent’

Two weeks ago, only former Law Minister C.Ve. Shanmugam, the prominent face of the party in the Vilupuram district, accused the AIADMK general secretary of “refusing to correct errors and suppressing dis-



Edappadi K. Palaniswami

sent” within the party.

Unlike Mr. Shanmugam, Mr. Vijayabhaskar did not launch a tirade against Mr. Palaniswami, but it was quite obvious that he did



Tough stand: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay addressing officials at a conference in Chennai on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A change should be brought about in the behaviour of those who disturb law and order,” he said in his opening remarks.

Safety of women should be ensured without any compromise and special arrangements should be made for their protection. Special attention should also be given to the safety of students and children, he said.

“Shops near schools should be continuously monitored. Periodic checks should be conducted if necessary. Those involved in drug-related

crimes should be immediately arrested and punished,” the Chief Minister said.

‘For social justice’

Mr. Vijay emphasised that the people elected the TVK-led government for social justice and for an administration that was transparent, honest, and corruption-free. “We must pay special attention to basic needs such as rations, education, drinking water, health, electricity, road facilities, and bus facilities,” he said.

“Regarding law and or-

der, you can decide freely. Whoever the wrongdoers are, no matter how powerful they are, they should be punished immediately and impartially according to the law. Innocent persons should not be penalised,” the Chief Minister added.

Collectors should hold online meetings with officials ahead of public grievance redress meetings. Mr. Vijay asked them to treat farmers, fishermen and persons with disabilities with courtesy and empathy while handling their grievances. Officials should conduct field visits regularly and take follow-up action on petitions received, he said.

The Chief Minister suggested that Collectors hold a law and order meeting every month and coordinate with the relevant departments.

He emphasised the importance of consulting legal experts on crucial cases so that wrongdoers do not escape the law.

Apart from District Collectors and Superintendents of Police, Deputy Inspectors General of Police, the Director General of Police and heads of various government departments also participated in the conference.

CCB summons former Minister as part of probe into alleged job fraud

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Job Fraud Investigation Wing of the Central Crime Branch (CCB) has issued summons to former Transport Minister S.S. Sivasankar (DMK), directing him to appear before investigators on Wednesday in connection with an alleged recruitment fraud involving a promise of employment in the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC).

According to police, the summons was served at Mr. Sivasankar's residence as part of the investigation into a complaint lodged by S. Srinivasan, 65, a retired Special Sub-Inspector of Police, that he was allegedly cheated of ₹23 lakh on the assurance of securing an Assistant Engineer's post for his son in the MTC. The summons come days after the arrest of L. Ilanchezhian, 60, in Erode by a special CCB team.

Investigators said Ilanchezhian claimed to have close political connections with Mr. Sivasankar and collected ₹23 lakh from Mr. Srinivasan in several instalments between 2023 and 2025, promising to arrange an MTC job for the complainant's son. However, neither the job was secured nor the money re-



S.S. Sivasankar

turned, the police said. During the arrest, the police recovered two identity cards from Ilanchezhian's possession as part of the evidence. Investigators also sealed Ilanchezhian's house in Ariyalur district.

Meanwhile, the Job Fraud Investigation Wing has moved the Egmore Magistrate Court seeking seven days' police custody of the accused for further interrogation. Following Ilanchezhian's arrest, Mr. Sivasankar said in a social media post that the accused had never worked as his personal assistant and denied any such association.

Police sources confirmed the complainant mentioned the name of the former Minister in the complaint and so summons were issued to Mr. Sivasankar, asking him to appear before the investigation officer concerned on Wednesday for an inquiry.

A few other senior leaders and former Ministers, Natham R. Viswanathan and S.P. Velumani too, who were made deputy general secretaries, have yet to meet Mr. Palaniswami.

Expected to join TVK

Mr. Vijayabhaskar's move follows a similar action on the part of his namesake and fellow legislator (representing Virallimalai) a few weeks ago. The two dissidents are expected to join the TVK.

Asked whether the quality of “obstinacy” on the part of Mr. Palaniswami is coming in the way of achieving an effective compromise between him and the dissidents, the party's

MP (Rajya Sabha) and supporter of the general secretary M. Dhanapal replied in the negative and wondered: “Does not the action of Edappadiar [Mr. Palaniswami] giving the dissidents new positions in the party reflect that he is quite flexible and considerate?”

‘Ruling party desperate’

The MP contended that as the ruling party was “desperate” to free itself of the hold of the two Communist parties and the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi, it is wooing legislators of the AIADMK to its side, so the TVK can acquire “greater strength, if not a majority of its own.”

Application process for MBBS/BDS begins

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Applications for admission to MBBS and BDS courses in Tamil Nadu commenced on Monday noon through the website - tmmedicaleducation.org.

Officials of the Selection Committee, Directorate of Medical Education and Research, said the application window would remain open till at least one week after the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) results are released. The NEET undergraduate re-examination was held on June 21.

Dos and don'ts

For candidates looking to apply, Manickavel Arumugam, education counsellor, shared a few dos and don'ts. “Admission happens only through government counselling. Do not fall into the trap of fraud-

sters. No one can secure an MBBS/BDS seat for you without going through counselling,” he said, adding that no one could obtain MBBS/BDS admission anywhere in India without passing NEET. Registration with individual colleges was not necessary (the exception is the management quota seats at Christian Medical College, Vellore), he said. If any candidate is unsure of securing a government quota seat, Mr. Arumugam recommended registering for the management quota too. “If you do not register now, you will not be able to add it at a later stage,” he said.

Mr. Arumugam urged candidates to consider their budget, keeping in mind that it is a long-term commitment. “Do not claim nativity if you are not a native of Tamil Nadu. Don't submit fake documents,” he added.

Making Rahul Gandhi PM in 2029 should be our objective, says new TNCC president

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Congress MP from Virudhunagar B. Manickam Tagore on Monday assumed charge as the president of the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) in the presence of senior leaders, Congress Ministers, MPs, and a few former TNCC chiefs at Sathyamurthy Bhavan in Chennai.

Mr. Tagore said assuming the post was akin to “running a marathon” and praised the contributions of his predecessors in building the party.

“Winning 40 out of 40 Lok Sabha seats (in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry) and ensuring that Rahul Gandhi becomes the Prime Minister in 2029 should be our target. Only Rahul Gandhi can ensure the



Outgoing TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai felicitating his successor B. Manickam Tagore. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

abolition of NEET, protection of our rights over the Cauvery, ensure the security of fishermen, provide a fair devolution of taxes to Tamil Nadu, and Centre's financial support. We have to build this narrative on the ground,” he said.

On his run-ins with DMK leaders in the recent past, Mr. Tagore said he would hit back at those who at-

tacked the Congress. “The TNCC is new to me. There may be certain issues with my approach. We are all human beings, but we have to understand that Congress alone is important,” he said. He appealed to Congress Ministers to be present at Sathyamurthy Bhavan one day of the week to meet the cadre.

Mr. Selvaperunthagai said: “I am handing over the responsibility in the same way I took over the responsibility in 2024. We started Village Committees across Tamil Nadu for which Peter Alphonse also took on the responsibility. As many as 17,654 ward committees have been formed and around 1,64,000 ID cards with QR codes have been distributed. I thank everyone for the opportunity.”

INBRIEF



Attack on ex-Kerala Minister:
KSU worker withdraws plea

A petition before the Kerala High Court by Kerala Students Union (KSU) worker Athul M.C., one of the accused in the alleged attack on former Health Minister Veena George, was withdrawn on Monday. The plea sought to dismiss the FIR registered over the alleged attempt to attack Ms. George at Kannur Railway Station in February. The petitioner requested withdrawal since the FIR had been amended to exclude “attempt to murder” in the course of the investigation.

Two bodies retrieved from
water tank in Krishna district

In a shocking incident, police on Monday retrieved two bodies allegedly dumped in a tank tied to a bike in Krishna district of Andhra Pradesh. As per witness accounts, unidentified persons allegedly tied the bodies to the bike and threw them into the tank. The victims had been reported missing since Saturday, said family members. A case under Section 194 of Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita has been registered, and a probe is under way, the police said.

Lokesh, Singapore Consul
General discuss investment

Singapore Consul General in Chennai Edgar Pang Tze Chiang called on Andhra Pradesh Minister Nara Lokesh at his residence on Monday. During the meeting, they discussed ways to strengthen the partnership between the State and Singapore. Mr. Lokesh sought Singapore’s support in enhancing bilateral cooperation in technology, trade, investments and the maritime sector. He outlined the State’s ‘Speed of Doing Business’ initiative and investment opportunities.

Sabarimala gold theft: report
finds conspiracy by TDB staff

Court permits SIT to register fresh case against officials; as per interim report, while giving permit for gold-plating *dwarapalakas*, the officials deliberately described the coverings as copper plates

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

An interim report submitted before the Kerala High Court by the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged misappropriation of gold from the Sabarimala Ayyappa temple during the course of gold-plating works, has mentioned criminal conspiracy by P.S. Prashanth, who was then the president of the Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB), among others.

Following this, the court permitted the SIT to register a fresh case against Mr. Prashanth and the others.



Judicial push: The Kerala High Court has asked the SIT to submit its final report expeditiously. FILE PHOTO

The report states that collected materials clearly establish the role of Murari Babu, Executive Officer, Sabarimala; Unnikrishnan Potti, sponsor for gold-plating the Dwarapalaka idols; Pankaj Bhandari, proprietor of Smart Creations, Chennai, where the idols

were taken for gold-plating; among others. Based on the interim report by S. Sasidharan, the officer leading the SIT, a Division Bench said stringent action ought to be initiated under the BNSS. The team was asked to ensure the final report is submitted as

‘No proof required in
enumeration stage’

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Electors in Karnataka will not have to produce any documents during the house-to-house enumeration for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls beginning on Tuesday, Chief Electoral Officer V. Anbu Kumar said on Monday.

Addressing a press conference, Mr. Kumar said Booth Level Officers will only distribute and collect enumeration forms during

the month-long exercise. He said that the forms will be in Kannada, but people can fill it up either in Kannada or in English.

The State’s house-to-house enumeration will continue till July 29. The draft electoral rolls will be published on August 5, after which electors can file claims and objections until September 4.

Following disposal of claims and objections by October 3, the final electoral rolls will be published on October 7.

Karnataka ex-CM’s
‘audio clip’ stirs row

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

An audio clip purportedly of senior BJP leader and former Karnataka Chief Minister D.V. Sadananda Gowda asking the party to wait till State president B.Y. Vijayendra completes his term in November before “kicking him out” went viral on Monday, causing a stir in the party.

It drew sharp reactions from Mr. Vijayendra’s camp, even as it yet again exposed factionalism with-

early as possible.

As per the interim report, the *dwarapalakas* (guardian deities), which were originally clad with gold in 1998, were transported to Chennai in 2019 at Mr. Potti’s request. While granting permission for the same, the TDB officers, deliberately described the coverings on the idols as copper plates. This was to remove the gold from the idols and instead plate a thin film of gold over them. The original gold cladding was removed at the Chennai firm. The extracted was misappropriated by the accused.

The case has been postponed for hearing on July 20.

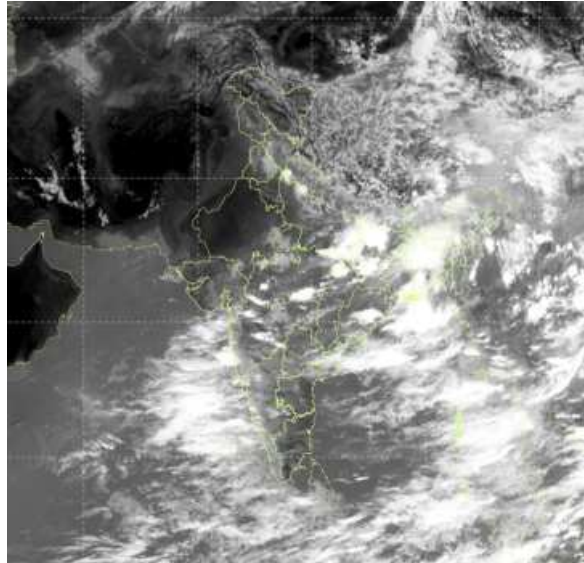
in the State BJP.

The audio clip, which Mr. Gowda said was fake, comes amid speculation that the party high command may opt for a revamp of the party’s State leadership, unhappy over the state of affairs of the unit, especially after cross-voting in the recently held Legislative Council polls.

Mr. Gowda said he would not comment on the audio since it was not his, adding, he would answer only if the high command asked him about it.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Odisha, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha, Chhattisgarh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal and South Interior Karnataka.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		33.4	26.9	Kurnool		35.1	
Ahmedabad		39.6	29.7	Lucknow		00.0	00.0
Aizawl		3.6	32.5	Madurai		37.5	26.4
Bengaluru		28.0		Mangaluru		28.4	
Bhopal		34.2		Mumbai		28.8	
Bhubaneswar		38.2		Mysuru		32.0	
Chandigarh		39.6	30.3	New Delhi		41.8	
Chennai		38.0	27.4	Patna		35.4	
Coimbatore		31.2	22.6	Port Blair		5.1	29.2
Dehradun		1.6	34.2	Prayagraj		41.0	30.8
Gangtok		23.4		Puducherry		38.2	27.5
Goa		30.5		Pune		34.2	
Guwahati				Raipur		36.3	
Hubballi		28.0	23.0	Ranchi		33.9	
Hyderabad		0.3	31.6	Shillong			
Imphal		0.2	32.1	Shimla		13.8	23.6
Jaipur			40.0	Srinagar			35.3
Kochi		29.0		Thiruvananthapuram		16.0	28.8
Kohima				Tiruchirappalli		37.7	27.0
Kolkata		34.8	29.0	Vijayawada		63.7	34.2
Kozhikode		28.1		Visakhapatnam		32.0	29.8

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		22		23	21		■ In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Sonapat.
Bengaluru		8		10		21	■ Haryana recorded an overall air quality index
Chennai		5		12		48	■ (AQI) score of 343
Delhi		8		60		103	■ indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In
Hyderabad		7		12		30	■ contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram
Kolkata		5		23		24	■ recorded a healthy AQI
Lucknow		34		12		31	■ score of 20
Mumbai		6		12		74	■
Pune			31	100		32	■
Visakhapatnam		12		55	12		■

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

BJP leader
arrested in
Telangana
over ruckus
in school

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Telangana police arrested a local BJP leader from Nizamabad district on Monday, two days after he and his supporters entered a school and assaulted the principal, citing unauthorised conduct of Urdu classes.

The incident took place at Bharat Chandra High School, also known as Bhavishya Darshini School, in Perkit village of Armoor mandal in Nizamabad.

Urdu classes

The issue began after a recently appointed Hindi teacher was found teaching Urdu to students of Classes I to V during Hindi classes. An inquiry by education and police officials had confirmed the allegation against the teacher.

BJP Armoor Town president Mandula Balu and his supporters entered the school and confronted the management over the issue. During the altercation, the principal was allegedly assaulted in the presence of police personnel.

The police registered a first information report against Mr. Balu and his associates under provisions relating to trespass, voluntarily causing hurt, grievous hurt and mischief, of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). A second case was registered against the school correspondent Malaiiah, principal Ameer Khan and teacher Huma Hania under Section 196(1) (b) of the BNS for allegedly promoting enmity between different groups and acts prejudicial to the maintenance of harmony.

BJP, Cong. leaders come to blows at corporation meet

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A council meeting of the BJP-led Thiruvananthapuram Corporation in Kerala on Monday witnessed violent scenes as BJP councillor and Education Standing Committee Chairperson Chempazhanchy Udayan allegedly attacked United Democrat-

ic Front’s (UDF) council leader K.S. Sabarinadhan and two women councillors of the Congress on Monday.

Mr. Udayan was seen charging at Mr. Sabarinadhan and a group of women councillors and forcefully snatching away the council attendance register.

Mr. Sabarinadhan alleged the fight broke out

after the UDF councillors obtained possession of the council attendance register and the minutes book which the Mayor had “kept hidden”. Mr. Udayan attempted to snatch the files, leading to the scuffle.

At a press conference after the meeting, the Mayor claimed that the UDF councillors had refused to return the attendance re-

gister after signing, leading to the scuffle. He added that “unfortunate incidents” which should not have happened occurred during the council meeting.

“The Mayor presented 700 agenda items within seven minutes and ran away from the council meeting. The attack on Mr. Sabarinadhan is the latest

instance of BJP’s use of political violence against the Opposition. Last week, the Mayor himself led an attack on protesting LDF councillors,” LDF council party leader S.P. Deepak said.

CPI(M) leader V. Sivankutty demanded that the State government take action against Mr. Udayan for the “unprovoked” attack.”

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

In Loving Memory of

09-03-1950 - 29-06-2026

Mr. Rajendran Ramachandran

Fondly known to family and friends as Raghu.

A beloved son, husband, father, grandfather, brother, and friend, he was blessed with the kindest of hearts, and his love for his family and courage defined his life.

He will forever live on in our hearts and memories and be deeply missed.

Fondly remembered by

His wife, Mrs. Mallika Rajendran, his children, Vivek and Pooja, daughter-in-law Suchitra, son-in-law Prashanth, and grandchildren Nithika, Navya, and Adhyanth.

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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DEATH

In loving memory of
Mr. Pookat Sivaramakrishnan
Date of death - 29 June 2026

Funeral - 1400 hours
30 June 2026
Ph - 9841400844

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

19th ANNIVERSARY
D.VENKATESAN
07 Nov 1945 - 30 Jun 2007
Fondly Remembered by
Wife V.PADMINI & RDM Family Members

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

In Loving Memory
Third Death Anniversary
Vijay Sargunar
26 April 1976 - 30 June 2023
Your voice is silent, smile is gone, but you live lives forever in our hearts. We miss you more than words can ever express. Always loved. Always remembered. Always missed.
Lovingly remembered by your family.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

4th ANNIVERSARY
Thiru. S. MANI
D.O.B: 03-08-1950 D.O.D: 30-06-2022
Our beloved Director
Sadly missed along life's way
Lovingly remembered every day
No longer in our life to share
But in our hearts you're always there
Fondly Remembered by
Management & staff
Phorotech Surfin (India) Pvt Ltd.,

DEATH

OBITUARY
K.N. JAYARAMAN
16.09.1929 - 28.06.2026
Beloved Husband, Father, Grandfather and Great Grandfather
His kindness, warmth, hard work and sincerity touched everyone that he met. We are grateful for the love he gave us without condition and for the example he has set for us to walk in his footsteps.
Vasantha Jayaraman
Jay Vasavan and Hemalatha Vasavan, Usha Sriram and K Sriram
Nanditha, Veena, Shyam and their families
Family, friends and loved ones

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची

ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सूचना
नेशनल कम्पेटीटीभ बिडिंग

टेंडर रेफरेंस नं०- प०नि०वि०/ राँची-०३ / 2026-27 दिनांक :- 29.06.2026

1.	कार्य का नाम	कटहल मोड़ से दलादली रोड (रिंग रोड) पथ के बौनेज कि०मी० 0.00 से कि०मी० 2.070 (कुल लम्बाई- 2.070 कि०मी०) के चौड़ीकरण एवं मजबूतीकरण/ पुनर्निर्माण कार्य वर्ष 2026-27
2.	अनुमानित प्राककलित राशि (रु० लाख में)	रु० 1770.92094 लाख (रुपये सत्रह करोड़ सत्तर लाख बानबे हजार चौरान्ने मात्र)।
3.	अग्रघन की राशि (रु० लाख में)	रु० 17.71 लाख (रुपये सत्रह लाख एकहत्तर हजार) मात्र।
4.	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	06 (छ) माह
5.	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	01.07.2026
6.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि/ समय	10.30 बजे पूर्वाह्न
7.	निविदा खोलने की तिथि/ समय	22.07.2026 12.00 बजे दोपहर तक
8.	निविदा प्रकाशित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता	23.07.2026 12.30 बजे अपराह्न।
9.	प्रोक्वोरमेंट पदाधिकारी का सम्पर्क संख्या	कार्यपालक अभियंता पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, मोहराबादी, राँची-834008.
10.	ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन संख्या	0651-2361018

- प्राककलित राशि एवं अग्रघन की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है, जिसे Tender Online Upload में देखा जा सकता है, एवं किसी भी प्रकार का बदलाव <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।
- नियम एवं शर्तों के लिए वेबसाइट <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखें।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची
PR 383577 Road Construction Dept Road Division Ranchi (26-27)_D

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची

ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सूचना नेशनल कम्पेटीटीभ बिडिंग

टेंडर रेफरेंस नं०-प०नि०वि०/ राँची-02/ 2026-27 दिनांक :- 29.06.2026

1.	कार्य का नाम	आशीर्वाद बैस्वेट (कर्मटोली-आरमांडी) पथ, MDR-016 पर से फायरिंग रेन्ज (बरियातु) (दूटी पथ पर) पथ (कुल लम्बाई-4.070 कि०मी०) का निर्माण कार्य वर्ष 2026-27
2.	अनुमानित प्राककलित राशि (रु० लाख में)	रु० 2759.86173 लाख (रुपये सत्ताईस करोड़ उनसठ लाख छियासी हजार एक सौ विहत्तर) मात्र।
3.	अग्रघन की राशि (रु० लाख में)	रु० 27.60 लाख (रुपये सत्ताईस लाख साठ हजार) मात्र।
4.	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	13 (तेरह) माह
5.	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	01.07.2026
6.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि/ समय	10.30 बजे पूर्वाह्न
7.	निविदा खोलने की तिथि/ समय	08.07.2026 3.00 बजे अपराह्न
8.	निविदा प्रकाशित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता	22.07.2026 12.00 बजे दोपहर तक
9.	प्रोक्वोरमेंट पदाधिकारी का सम्पर्क संख्या	23.07.2026 12.30 बजे अपराह्न।
10.	ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन संख्या	कार्यपालक अभियंता पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, मोहराबादी, राँची-834008.
11.	ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन संख्या	0651-2361018

- प्राककलित राशि एवं अग्रघन की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है, जिसे Tender Online Upload में देखा जा सकता है, एवं किसी भी प्रकार का बदलाव <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।
- नियम एवं शर्तों के लिए वेबसाइट <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> पर देखें।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची
PR 383575 (Road Construction Dept Road Division Ranchi)26-27*D



Delayed honour

Operational secrecy during wars is a must, but there must be accountability

War is secretive and strategy may require deception. But that is no good explanation for the fact that the Narendra Modi government took over a year before formally acknowledging that six soldiers had lost their lives in Operation Sindoor in 2025. India had launched cross-border military strikes in Pakistan in retaliation for the Pahalgam terrorist attack, in April 2025, that killed 26 innocent people. From the beginning, the government has been reluctant to share any meaningful details of Operation Sindoor even as it continuously kept the hyperbolic self-congratulatory posture. Its decision to not publicly acknowledge and honour the supreme sacrifice of the fallen soldiers contemporaneously was hardly a sign of any wise strategy. Casualties can happen in any military operation and that is a key consideration in any military planning, and more importantly, the political decision to go to war or not. Not being transparent about losses, human and material, may serve the political interests of the ruling party, but not national interest. By trying to be clever and selective about facts, the government undermined its own credibility and did a disservice to those who paid with their lives. Soon after the operation concluded in May 2025, the then Director General of Military Operations (DGMO), Lieutenant General Rajiv Ghai, paid tribute, during a press briefing on May 11, 2025, to Indian military personnel who had made the supreme sacrifice, though their names were not disclosed.

The cremations were done with full military honours. In August 2025, Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh visited the family of Sergeant Surendra Kumar, who was killed during the operation, while the Ministry of Defence also announced gallantry awards for the fallen personnel. Tributes were simultaneously carried on the Indian Army’s official social media platforms. In the Lok Sabha on July 28, 2025, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said that “no Indian soldiers were harmed” during Operation Sindoor. Following accusations that it has misled Parliament, the government is now explaining that the Minister’s remarks were made in the context of reports that Indian aircraft were shot down and were meant to clarify that no pilot was killed during the mission. The government has also maintained that details relating to aircraft losses during the conflict remain operationally sensitive and refused to disclose them. There is a distinction to be made between operational secrecy and requirements of public accountability. War is a stark demonstration of the fact that it is the public that always pays for all actions of the government. A public accounting of the gains and the losses is the best way to ensure wise decision making.

Caught in the middle

India must prioritise reduction of harm from drug abuse

India is located between two major drug-producing regions: Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Iran to the west and Myanmar, Thailand, and Laos to the east. While the West has historically dominated heroin production, the International Narcotics Control Board has said Myanmar has become the world’s leading source of illicit opium while East and Southeast Asia remain major sources of methamphetamine. Officials have said drugs are being received at Gujarat, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu via maritime routes. Similarly, some drugs are produced domestically using illegally diverted pharmaceutical ingredients, aided by the fact that individuals possessing small quantities of heroin can attract up to six months’ imprisonment, whereas drugmakers that cannot account for lakhs of doses often face only slaps on the wrist. The rise of Myanmar, where the territory under ethnic armed organisations is expanding, as a key source is also troubling since it shares a border with India. The Narcotics Control Bureau has noted a dramatic surge in the use of drones to smuggle drugs across borders, especially over Punjab. Traffickers are organising over the darknet and using cryptocurrencies. The pillars of India’s response thus aim to keep the enforcement regime from being out-innovated and improve regulatory certainty.

States are trying to adopt a ‘whole of society’ approach recognising the public health and social dimensions. However, India needs to do more. Physical abuse and forced detoxification are frequently reported from many private centres. Punjab has an extensive network of de addiction centres providing opioid substitution therapy, and some northeastern States to a secondary extent, but most large States have much less access relative to need. Most Integrated Rehabilitation Centres for Addicts are located in urban areas whereas the highest density of addicts in Punjab are in border villages and rural pockets. Likewise, relapse is often treated as a moral failure and many addicts avoid government centres fearing social ostracisation, particularly in rural North India. The persistence of criminal records for small-scale possession prevents youth from getting jobs, reducing their odds of escaping the drug-crime cycle. Although the Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyaan has said it has sensitised over six crore women, facilities dedicated to women are scarce and concentrated in urban areas; stigma, caregiving responsibilities, and lack of gender-responsive treatment keep many women from seeking or completing care. Finally, as evidence shows, disrupted supply can drive many users to cheaper alternatives unless accompanied by effective treatment. India must therefore shift public focus from seizures and arrests to the number of lives restored.

For 45 years after Independence, India grew at an anaemic 3% – the infamous “Hindu rate of growth”. Triggered by a balance-of-payments crisis, India found the gumption to liberalise. Within a decade, GDP growth surged. The lesson: crisis breeds reform, and reform breeds exponential outcomes. Artificial Intelligence (AI) provides the same transformational leverage that liberalisation provided in 1991. The question is not whether India can afford to invest – it is whether India can afford not to. After 12 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s leadership, India has reached another WhatsApp moment in reform – dare I say, to take it from a Hindu rate of growth to the Bharat rate of growth – 8% and beyond for the next decade.

The case for making tokens free

India has since proven that it can leapfrog entire generations of infrastructure. Aadhaar enrolled 1.38 billion people in a biometric identity system, the largest on earth. UPI now processes 250 billion annual transactions worth \$3.4 trillion, handling 50% of the world’s real-time digital payments. Reliance Jio, launched in 2016, added 100 million subscribers in just five months and made mobile data essentially free. How India can replicate its Aadhaar, data availability deluge and UPI miracles in the age of AI – by embracing open models, diversifying compute hardware, and making tokens as free as data.

India spends just about 0.65% of its GDP on research and development (R&D), well below China (2.4%), the United States (3.5%), South Korea (4.9%), and Israel (5.4%). The excuse of the socialist Congress governments of 1947-1991 was: “we can’t afford anything more”, which does not and should not apply now. The central question is this: Has the time come to make AI tokens free? If so, how do we do it? Can we begin by making tokens free for the country’s top 100 national R&D institutions and 5,000 schools, so that AI becomes a teammate for scientists and students alike?

India spends approximately \$49 billion each year subsidising calories, chemicals, and carbon. The question is whether it is now ready to subsidise cognition. The answer is that it already can – at a fraction of what it spends today. The entire AI token subsidy for the country’s top 100 universities and national R&D institutions, along with 5,000 high schools, would cost about \$2 billion annually – roughly 0.06% of GDP. The AI investment is around one-fourteenth of India’s food subsidy, one-tenth of its fertilizer subsidy, and less than the amount paid to compensate oil marketing companies for LPG under-recoveries in a single quarter. This is not a moonshot budget. It is a rounding error in India’s existing welfare expenditure – but one with the potential to generate transformative, compounding returns.

India does not need more money; it needs new priorities, new frameworks, and some reallocation. First, AI tokens can be funded



Srivatsa Krishna
IAS officer

Reforms 3.0 should focus on building an AI nation, and India cannot afford to miss this opportunity

without cutting a single rupee from existing beneficiaries by merely freezing subsidy growth for a year. (The fertilizer subsidy alone has been compounding at 11% CAGR over the past decade.) Second, India should forge a public-private partnership with hyperscalers such as AWS, Google, and Microsoft, exchanging data centre land, power subsidies, and data sovereignty assurances for free inference capacity. India’s 1.4-billion-user market gives it negotiating leverage that few countries can match, though such techno-commercial negotiations, shaped by geopolitics and uncertainty, will require considerable skill. Third, if necessary, paid enterprise tiers can cross-subsidise free access for schools and research institutions.

Free data worked and free tokens will too. The government did not directly subsidise Jio. Instead, it created the right regulatory environment through spectrum auctions, net neutrality, infrastructure sharing, and a controversial long pilot.

The result: data prices fell from about \$3 per GB to \$0.10 in under three years. The same playbook can apply to AI tokens. Create the right conditions, and the market will deliver abundance. India’s role is not to write the cheque, but to make it unnecessary.

Hosting models

India must build the competence to host and operate large language models, not merely consume them through APIs from San Francisco or Beijing. With Sarvam, it has already shown that frontier models can be trained on Indian soil. The next step is to host models such as Qwen, DeepSeek, Kimi, Llama, and Sarvam on sovereign infrastructure, even if some open-source models originate from China. The models may be free, but the intelligence to host them at scale is not. AI infrastructure should be treated as a strategic national capability, much like what the government has already done for space and nuclear programmes. India should pursue a hybrid strategy that combines sovereign and open-source models to avoid dependence on any single ecosystem. Open-source models offer four key advantages: sovereignty by reducing reliance on foreign APIs that can be restricted overnight; lower costs by eliminating per-token licensing fees, thereby enabling free education and research uses; customisation for Indic languages and cultural contexts; and transparency through auditable model weights for government and defence applications.

Hosting LLMs at national scale is not “just deploy a container”. India must develop deep expertise in availability (multi-region redundancy, 99.99% uptime SLAs for critical government services; latency (<200ms token latency across Tier-2/3 cities); efficiency (like batch scheduling to maximise tokens-per-watt); security (data residency compliance, prompt injection defence, audit trails).

India cannot afford to be locked into a

single-vendor monopoly for its AI compute future. NVIDIA’s dominance comes at extraordinary cost – both financial and strategic. NVIDIA controls 80%+ of AI training hardware but creates deep vendor lock-in that extends far beyond hardware. For India to build sovereign AI infrastructure for 1.4 billion people, the math simply does not work at NVIDIA pricing.

India spent relatively little to build UPI; it cannot afford to spend \$50 billion on NVIDIA GPUs. The alternative hardware ecosystem is not just more economical – it is strategically essential. India should adopt a 40:30:30 hardware mix rather than rely on a single vendor. Around 40% should be built on AWS Trainium and AMD for cost-effective inference workloads available in India. Another 30% should use Google TPUs for research, model training, and academic partnerships. The remaining 30% should rely on NVIDIA for specialised training, legacy compatibility, and a domestic silicon hedge.

AI token policy, implementation timeline

India should announce a National AI Token Policy and implement it over the next 24 months. It should begin by signing public-private partnership agreements with AWS, Google, and Microsoft to establish a multi-vendor sovereign compute framework. The first pilot should provide unlimited research tokens to the top 20 IITs and the IISc. As hyperscaler inference capacity comes online, India should open an API sandbox for 500 startups, expand access to 100 universities, and launch an AI literacy pilot across 500 high schools in 10 States. The programme should culminate in the publication of the country’s first sovereign Indic AI model benchmarks.

Thereafter India needs to scale the ecosystem through cross subsidies as mentioned above and deploy fine-tuned models into health care, agriculture, judiciary and education. It must follow this up with full deployment at 5,000 high schools and all 22 languages. With this India’s token consumption will enter the global top five. In two years, India-trained models will become competitive on international benchmarks and 10,000+ AI-native startups will bloom, rocketing GDP growth.

In sum, India’s AI leapfrog is a *sine qua non* for national transformation. India needs to replicate its DPI (digital public infrastructure) miracles in the age of AI by embracing open models, diversifying compute hardware, and making tokens as free as data. India has all the necessary conditions – favourable policies, stable macroeconomy, prodigious talent and technology institutions – to become a global leader in AI applications. The sufficient condition is India’s decisive, visionary leadership. It will take three moves. One decade. And a transformed (AI) nation.

The views expressed are personal

Preparing India for China’s missile challenge

Missiles are reshaping warfare, making conflicts faster, cheaper, and more political. A limited volley of conventional missiles can paralyse a country, disrupt critical infrastructure, and complicate decision-making. With China having deployed more than 200 conventional missile launchers opposite India, the key question is how this missile superiority could shape a future conflict.

China’s arsenal

While India views conventional missiles primarily as deterrents, China sees them as instruments of both political coercion and war-fighting. The threat of missile strikes alone may achieve strategic objectives without triggering a full-scale war. A barrage targeting critical infrastructure deep inside India could force New Delhi to fight on two fronts: a border conflict and a missile campaign against its hinterland.

The two missile bases located at Korla and Kunming can fire a range of conventional missiles (DF-15B, DF-16, DF-21C and DF-26). DF-15B, DF-16 and DF-21C are most suited to hit military targets along the borders; whereas the DF-26 can hit high-value targets in depth. Further, their hypersonic missiles (DF-100 and CJ-1000) can hit deeper, with no launch warning. This becomes a major vulnerability, as India has no reliable defence against it.

Consequently, China’s inventory reduces the salience of the Himalayas to provide strategic depth. The DF-26, being dual-role, raises the risk of escalation. While China shoots down from the Tibetan Plateau, India has to shoot over the Himalayas. This impacts missile detection timings. Moreover, India’s missile inventory is still evolving, with limitations in both range and diversity. Its long-range systems – including Agni, the Long-Range Land Attack Cruise Missile (LR-LACM) – Nirbhay, and BrahMos – and their variants are yet to be fully integrated. India also lacks robust real-time targeting capabilities, has



Harinder Singh
Retired Lieutenant General and an independent analyst

India needs to build a rocket force before China’s missile advantage grows further

finite missile stockpiles, and is still developing its hypersonic technology. Importantly, its rocket force remains a conceptual construct, with significant policy and organisational issues yet to be resolved.

Without a rocket force, India would have little choice but to absorb a Chinese missile strike. On the contrary, if India has one, both get hurt to varying degrees. That is when the missile math kicks in – in terms of mutual vulnerability. If China launches 100 missiles, India must be able to inflict significant damage – not necessarily through equal numbers, but through comparable effects. India should therefore aim to build a credible conventional missile inventory; otherwise, it risks being forced into a stalemate even before the border war begins.

Ideally, India’s rocket force should deliver three effects. First, it should be able to hold the PLA’s Western Theatre Command (WTC) at risk by having the threat to target deep inside Tibet and Xinjiang. Second, it should be capable of degrading the PLA’s road and rail infrastructure, airbases, and logistics installations along the border. Third, it must enable field commanders to strike PLA camps, gun positions, and ammunition dumps in the tactical battle area. In essence, India needs a rocket force capable of engaging strategic, operational, and tactical military and economic targets from a single command authority.

Three aspects are important. First, at the doctrinal level, India must adopt counter-value strikes as part of its conventional missile strategy. This would require rethinking the scope and scale of its counter-force doctrine and developing a unified target list. Service- or agency-specific target lists have little place in time-sensitive missile warfare. The rocket force must also have the authority to execute pre-designated precautionary strikes in the opening hours of a conflict. Without pre-delegated launch authority, India would risk defeat at the outset.

Second, at the structural level, whatever blueprint is adopted for the rocket force, it must be placed under the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS). Keeping it service-specific would undermine operational effectiveness. India must also expand its medium- and intermediate-range ballistic missile (MRBM/IRBM) inventory, including Agni variants, to hold targets such as Korla and Kunming at reciprocal risk. This would raise the costs of any Chinese use of the DF-26. Fast-tracking the development of hypersonic missiles is vital, especially since the DF-100 is already part of the PLA Rocket Force’s order of battle (ORBAT).

Third, at the technological level, India’s missile industry faces significant challenges. Private sector participation must expand to complement the efforts of the DRDO. Major missile programmes have suffered from cost overruns and delays, while critical gaps in advanced air propulsion systems, semiconductors, and high-grade materials continue to hamper self-reliance. Dependence on foreign suppliers for high-end components remains a strategic vulnerability. Greater investment in R&D and end-to-end private-sector manufacturing will be essential.

Interim steps

Since a rocket force will take time to become operational, India must adopt interim measures. First, disperse IAF assets and harden airbases to reduce vulnerability and force an adversary to expend more missiles. Second, optimise air-defence deployment to compel the PLA Rocket Force to target the air-defences rather than critical infrastructure. Third, strengthen long-range conventional strike capabilities to hold targets in Tibet and Xinjiang at risk, creating reciprocal vulnerability. Finally, expand satellite surveillance to detect mobile launchers, particularly DF-26 systems, improving the chances of early neutralisation.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Ayodhya row

There is a glaring contrast between the government’s policies in monitoring foreign funds flow to NGOs and the management of huge funds for the Ram temple in Ayodhya at home. There are hardly any safeguards and

accountability for the enormous funds given by the public for the Ram temple. The genuineness of the ruling party’s avowed love for Hinduism comes under a cloud when such scams are taking place. **Matthew Adukanli**, Chennai

K. Bhagyaraj

The passing of filmmaker K. Bhagyaraj marks the end of a remarkable chapter in Indian cinema. Yet, even so, he has left behind a legacy that transcends his artistic achievements. His decision to donate his eyes stands as a profound testament to

altruism, compassion, and an unwavering commitment to the welfare of others. **Nagarajamani M.V.**, Hyderabad

Bhagyaraj had the rare ability to transform everyday situations into memorable cinematic

experiences. The title “Screenplay King” is a fitting tribute to a man who had the power to create unforgettable moments. **A.P. Thiruvadi**, Chennai

We have lost an extraordinary talent who

popularised Tamil cinema through diverse themes. Cinema has lost two stalwarts (Bharathiraja), marking the end of an era.

M. Pradyu, Thalikkavu, Kannur, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

A mysterious luncheon in Dachigam

From Page One

Dozens killed as Pak. targets Afghan militants

Their war earlier this year killed hundreds of Afghans and displaced tens of thousands, according to the UN.

There have been sporadic attacks since a cease-fire was reached in March, with Pakistani strikes in June killing 13 people, Afghan officials said.

Islamabad is mediating between the United States and Iran to end their war in West Asia, but Pakistan says its battle against militancy at home requires its strikes on Afghanistan.

Explosives were detonated and gunmen opened fire inside a Rangers paramilitary camp in Karachi on Saturday in one of the worst militant attacks in Pakistan's most populous city in years.

Authorities said three paramilitary personnel were killed and that they had detained an Afghan involved in the attack.

Pakistan says its forces use "precise targeting" to aim at militant hideouts and weapons stores, especially those of the TTP that has waged a violent campaign against Pakistan for years.

Afghan authorities have repeatedly denied that the country is used by militants and say Pakistani operations have caused a heavy civilian death toll.

U.S., Iran pause strikes but disagree on talks

The U.S. and Iran agreed to an interim deal earlier this month that calls for Tehran to dilute its stockpile of enriched uranium. It also waives U.S.-backed sanctions on the country while opening the Strait of Hormuz and giving each side 60 days to hammer out broader agreements.

In recent days, Iran has twice attacked vessels in the Strait of Hormuz – including a tanker filled with Qatari crude – following efforts to open Oman's territorial waters to both inbound and outbound traffic from the Persian Gulf.

The attacks drew retaliatory American air-strikes and raised concerns that negotiations to reach a formal end to the war could be disrupted. Iran launched drone and missile attacks targeting Bahrain and Kuwait on Sunday.

Pakistan, a key mediator, has said talks would resume on Tuesday.

Radio-tagged vulture electrocuted in T.N.

"There have long been calls for captive-bred birds to be released into Mudumalai to bolster populations. With this reintroduction having failed, steps must be taken to identify why the bird was unable to adapt," said a conservationist from the Nilgiris.

"We had captured the bird multiple times and released it into the Sigur, hoping it would acclimatise," said R. Kiruba Shankar, Field Director of MTR. However, on Sunday, during one the bird's explorations of Ebbanad in the Nilgiris forest division, it came into contact with a power line and was killed, officials confirmed.

"We will have discussions with the BNHS to understand the reasons for why this particular bird was unable to acclimatise and adapt. We will also find out if the other captive-bred birds released in other parts too have faced similar challenges," he said.

S. Bharathidasan, secretary of Arulagam, a conservation NGO, said power lines that cross through vulture habitats need to be reinforced with bunch-cabling and need to be insulated to prevent birds and other wildlife from being accidentally electrocuted.

Surveillance boost: Army to raise 'Baaz Battalions'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Army is raising dedicated 'Baaz Battalions' to significantly enhance its Remotely Piloted Aircraft (RPA) capability, a move aimed at strengthening battlefield surveillance, intelligence gathering and rapid response through a specialised drone force, defence sources said.

Sources in the Indian Army have confirmed the development and said that the new battalions will be built upon the Army's existing RPA Flights and will comprise a specialist pool of trained personnel responsible for operating and managing Remotely Piloted Aircraft systems.

The Baaz Battalions will centralise the Army's expanding drone capabilities and will be designed to handle the entire lifecycle of RPA operations.

Rijiju cites border infrastructure push after Chinese incursion claims

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Days after a tribal body in Arunachal Pradesh alleged that it was "losing their land, inch by inch, day by day to China" in the Taksing area, Union Minister Kiren Rijiju said that although India had started "late", it had begun building roads and other infrastructure in border areas.

Mr. Rijiju, who represents the Arunachal West constituency in the State, told *The Hindu* that Taksing was connected by road only in 2019.

"Though late, we are now building roads and other infrastructure in border areas. We are catching up," said Mr. Rijiju, when asked about the claims of Chinese incursions made by the Nah Welfare Society (NWS) at Taksing in Upper Subansiri district of Arunachal Pradesh.

The June 26 letter by Ke-



Kiren Rijiju

ru Chader, president, NWS, to the Deputy Commissioner of Upper Subansiri district stated that in the past 10 to 15 years, activities of People's Liberation Army (PLA) in the border areas of Taksing circle have increased manifold with an intention to occupy as much land as possible.

In a statement, the Indian Army said, "We have seen some media reports alleging recent encroachment by Chinese PLA and

setting up of camps in Arunachal Pradesh. These reports are incorrect and without any basis."

According to a Foreign Ministry response in Parliament in 2008, China disputes the International Boundary between India and China in the Eastern Sector and claims approximately 90,000 square kilometres of Indian territory in Arunachal Pradesh.

Tache Chader, the general secretary of NWS, said that due to the presence of Chinese forces, the locals were unable to take their cattle out for grazing. He told *The Hindu* that the group was yet to get a response from the authorities regarding the letter.

"We can no longer access the land that belonged to our ancestors. The Chinese are expanding and building roads at a fast pace," he said.

The June 26 letter said that the Chinese govern-

ment is expanding its territory by "occupying new and important places of our land situated at border area."

It said China had constructed roads, bridges and set up military camps in many places.

3,488-km-long border

India shares 3,488 km of border with China that runs along Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim, and Arunachal Pradesh.

According to Union Home Ministry, the border is not fully demarcated and the process of clarifying and confirming the Line of Actual Control is in progress.

"The area is characterised by high altitude terrain and thick habitation which have resulted in inadequate development of infrastructure in these regions," the Ministry said.

Death penalty for accused in Pune rape, murder case

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

A special court in Maharashtra's Pune district on Monday sentenced to death the 65-year-old man convicted of the rape and murder of a three-and-a-half-year-old girl in Nasrapur village of Bhore taluka.

Special Judge S.R. Salunke pronounced the sentence days after the court convicted Bhimrao Prabhakar Kamble on June 25 under multiple provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

The verdict comes within 60 days of the crime on May 1 that sparked widespread outrage and protests across the State.

Terming the case "rarest of the rare", the judge rejected the defence's plea for leniency.

Cong. seeks Rajnath's resignation over Army deaths during Sindoor

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stepping up its attack on the Centre over the deaths of six military personnel during Operation Sindoor, the Congress on Monday demanded the resignation of Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, accusing him of "lying" in Parliament by stating that no Indian soldier had been killed in the operation.

The party also demanded an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Addressing a press conference, chairperson of the Congress's Ex-servicemen Department Col. Rohit Chaudhry (Retd.) and Wing Commander Anuma Acharya (Retd.) alleged that by concealing the deaths of six personnel – five from the Indian Army and one from the Indian Air Force – during the May 2025 operation, the Naren-

dra Modi government had denied them due public recognition and honour.

Wing Commander Acharya claimed that previous governments had publicly honoured every soldier who made the supreme sacrifice, and accused the present dispensation of "politicising the armed forces".

Col. Chaudhry accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of using "soldiers as props" while seeking votes in the name of the armed forces, and questioned why it had taken 13 months for their names to be made public.

"When Defence Minister Rajnath Singh was lying in Parliament that no soldier had been martyred, BJP MPs were clapping. Rajnath Singh has insulted the country's army and soldiers. We demand his resignation," Col. Chaudhry said.

Bengal passes preventive detention, legal curbs Bill

Govt. can detain a person for a year to prevent anti-social activity; CM Suwendu Adhikari says State 'will not misuse [law]... for political vendetta'; law won't stand legal scrutiny, says Trinamool MLA

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The West Bengal Assembly on Monday passed two controversial laws providing for detention of 'anti-socials' for a year and restricting access to a lawyer for such persons, and payment of compensation by those accused of damaging private or public property.

The West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-Social Activities Bill, 2026 empowers the government to detain a person if it deems necessary to stop future anti-social activity for almost a year. It said the government can detain those "generally reputed to be desperate and dangerous to the community".

The Bill proposes constitution of an advisory board where every detention case will be scrutinised within three weeks. The board, which will comprise a chairperson who is or has been a High Court judge, will decide if a person remains in detention or has to be released.

Section 10 (4) of the Bill states, "A detained person shall not be ordinarily represented by a legal practi-

Cracking down

The West Bengal government says the newly introduced Bills aim to curb anti-social activities

- The West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-Social Activities Bill, 2026, allows preventive detention for up to one year if authorities believe a person may engage in future anti-social activities. Cases will be reviewed by an advisory board headed by a current or former High Court judge
- The Bill states that detained

persons will ordinarily not be represented by a lawyer before the advisory board, though the board may make exceptions

- The West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order (Amendment) Bill, 2026, empowers authorities to recover compensation from those found responsible for damage to public or private property

tioner before an advisory board." The proviso of the same sub-section says that the board may remove this prohibition in appropriate cases which should be recorded in writing.

Another legislation passed, titled "The West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order (Amendment) Bill, 2026", imposes a payment of compensation by persons committing offences such as damage to public or private property.

'Won't misuse'

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said such a law has

become necessary because of the criminalisation of politics and added that similar laws have been implemented in Maharashtra, Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Jharkhand.

Mr. Adhikari referred to incidents of mob violence when the Trinamool Congress was in power, particularly the killings of Haragobinda Das and Chandan Das in April 2025.

"We will not misuse this law. This law will not be used against anyone for the purpose of political vendetta," he said, amidst

concern from the Opposition.

Trinamool MLA from Chanchal and former IPS officer Prasun Banerjee described certain provisions of the Bill as "scary" and said the law will not stand judicial scrutiny. He said by empowering the administration, the BJP government is creating a "Frankenstein" with sweeping powers. He said that by allowing District Magistrates to issue warrants, the Bill is trying to create a "State within the State".

'Anarchy is prevailing'

The State's Parliamentary Affairs Minister Sankar Ghosh said that "anarchy" was prevailing in society because of the Trinamool's 15-year rule and those opposing the Bill want the anarchy to stay. "Right to protest can be a fundamental right but right to destroy public property cannot be a right," he said.

Minister Agnimitra Paul said the Trinamool government was run by "goons" and the new law is an attempt at course correction.

Several Opposition MLAs said the Bill will curb peaceful protests and students' movements.

Maharashtra TET paper leak points to an inter-State racket, finds investigation team

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the Maharashtra Teacher Eligibility Test paper leak has found that the case appears to be part of an inter-State racket. Of the three arrested accused, two are from Bihar, while the third, identified as Dheeraj Kumar, is from Haryana. Police teams have been dispatched to Bihar, Haryana, and Delhi as the investigation expands.

All the three accused are currently in police custody. Authorities are also examining whether provisions of the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) can be invoked against those found guilty.



Opposition leaders stage a protest at the Maharashtra Legislative Assembly against the TET paper leak in Mumbai on Monday. PTI

The police had received a tip-off on the morning of June 27 about an attempt to sell the TET question paper in Bhiwandi.

Acting on the information, a trap was laid in the Kongaon area, where Rajiv Shah, Akash Kumar, and Dheeraj Kumar were ap-

prehended. During the operation, police seized mobile phones, debit and credit cards, cash, and four physical copies of the TET question paper intended for the June 28 examination. Officials from the Maharashtra State Council of Examinations (MSCE) later confirmed that the seized papers matched the original examination papers. A case was registered at Kongaon Police Station under the Thane City Police Commissionerate.

The accused have been booked under Sections 318 (4), 316(5), and 61(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), along with Sections 11(1)(2)(3) and 12(1)(2) of the Maharashtra Competitive Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024,

and Sections 6 and 8 of the Maharashtra Prevention of Malpractices at Universities, Boards and Other Specified Examinations Act, 1982.

Priya Shinde, Deputy Commissioner of the MSCE, said candidates do not have to register again for the re-test nor will they need to pay any fee when the test is rescheduled.

School Education Minister Dada Bhuse is facing calls for resignation from the Opposition parties over the paper leak.

He said that a committee headed by the Chief Secretary will be formed to work out modalities of conducting the TET and other State-level examinations through the online mode.

(With PTI inputs)

Court extends custody of 10 accused in NEET-UG case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Monday extended till July 11 the judicial custody of 10 persons arrested in connection with the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case.

Special Judge Vijeta Singh Rawat of Rouse Avenue Court allowed the CBI's application seeking extension of custody.

The accused persons, Yash Yadav, Mangilal Biwal, Dinesh Biwal, Vikas Biwal, Dhyananjay Lokhande, Tejas Harshad Shah, Shubham Khairnar, Manisha Waghmare, Manisha Havaladar and Dr. Manoj Shirure, were produced before the court through video conferencing.

Bihar Governor and MoS to attend Khamenei's funeral

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI



Lt. Gen. Syed Ata Hasnain

Bihar Governor Lt. General Syed Ata Hasnain (ret'd) and Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita are likely to lead the Indian delegation to Iran for the funeral ceremonies of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, sources familiar with the plans told *The Hindu*.

The final composition of the delegation is yet to be firmed up, officials said.

Khamenei was killed in Israeli strikes on February 28, the first day of the U.S.-Israeli operation.

Last week, President Masoud Pezeshkian had invited Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the burial-related ceremonies in Iran. However, it is understood that Mr. Modi has prior commitments to travel to Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand from July 6.

Iran has invited a large group of foreign dignitaries to the burial-related events that will begin on July 3 and continue till July 9.

The choice of Mr. Hasnain and Mr. Margherita has drawn criticism from veteran diplomats here. Talmiz Ahmad, India's former Ambassador to Saudi Arabia, has said that he is "deeply disappointed".

"This is not the appropriate representation, given the high stature of the person concerned. Khamenei is held in very high regard in India. He has met all the Prime Ministers of the past four decades, including our present Prime Minister," said Mr. Ahmad, while referring to the changes sweeping the region that require India to make its diplomatic moves carefully.

Commentators here described the funeral as a "big opportunity" for India to restructure its West Asia policy. However, the choice of the delegation indicate that India is not recognising the importance of the event, they said.

In 2024, then Vice-President Jagdeep Dhankhar represented the government at the funeral of President Ebrahim Raisi, after he died in a helicopter crash.

Kharge reappointed Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition; seeks stronger coordination

Rabri likely to vacate official bungalow on July 5

Plea seeks securing of digital evidence in Ram Temple case

Ayodhya case will have long-term consequences for the Sangh Parivar

Ayodhya donation

row: all 8 accused

in judicial custody

INBRIEF



Govt. launches platform to track maternal, child health

Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah recently launched the PM Family Care Tracker (PM-FCT), a digital platform aimed at strengthening maternal and child health, nutrition, and family welfare through real-time monitoring of beneficiaries. Introduced as a pilot project in Gujarat, the platform seeks to integrate health, nutrition, and welfare services by tracking pregnant women, newborns, infants, children, and adolescents up to 18 years. The platform also features digital Health Passports for families, dashboards to facilitate delivery of government welfare schemes, and alerts for vaccinations and essential health services.

JKLF chief among 5 named in chargesheet in Sarla Bhat case

After 36 years, the Jammu and Kashmir Police's special cell, State Investigation Agency (SIA), on Monday named Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front chief Yasin Malik among five others in the chargesheet filed in the killing of Kashmiri Pandit Sarla Bhat, a nurse at the Sher-i-Kashmir Institute of Medical Sciences, in 1990. As per SIA, the investigation “conclusively established that the killing of Bhat was not an isolated act of violence but part of a larger terrorist conspiracy orchestrated under the command and control of the JKLF”. The investigation revealed the involvement of Malik and others “in executing the abduction and brutal killing”.

CBSE relaxes 3-language policy for Classes 7, 8, 9

The current 2026-27 batch of Class 10 will not have to follow the new language policy, the Board says; in Class 9, the third language will be evaluated only by an school-based internal assessment

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI



Concessions made: NEP'20 recommends learning 3 languages, with at least 2 of the 3 languages being native to India.

Students currently in Classes 7, 8, and 9 who have already opted for two foreign languages will continue with them, while also studying an additional Indian language (*Bharatiya Bhasha*), the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) said in the revised guidelines issued on Monday.

The Board, in a circular issued in May, had said that students in Class 9 too would have to adopt the three-language policy, where two of three languages they learn should be native to India. Following this, parents of students who were learning foreign languages had protested against the abrupt switch.

Rule relaxed
Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan stated last week that students in Classes 7, 8, and 9 who have taken foreign languages could continue their studies in their respective selected options. The current batch of Class 10 will not have to fol-

low the new language policy and will continue with the old system of two languages, the Board said.

The current batches studying in Classes 7, 8, and 9 would not be required to give Board examination in third language when they progress to Class 10, the statement added.

For Class 9, the third language (R3) will be assessed by the school through an internal school-based assessment.

The National Education Policy (NEP), 2020, recommends learning three languages, with at least two of the three languages being native to India.

The CBSE, in its press statement on Monday, said the introduction of the

a non-native language such as English or French.

A student studying one Indian language and one non-native language (for example Tamil and English), may choose any Indian language as the third language (R3).

A student studying two non-native languages (for example English and French), as a special one-time relaxation, may continue with those two non-native languages and need to add one Indian language as third language (R3).

The CBSE and NCERT will provide grade-appropriate learning resources to help students learn the third language, the press release states.

The dedicated R3 textbooks for Class 6 in 22 Scheduled *Bhartiya Bhashas* are being made available on www.ncert.nic.in.

Some categories exempted from the three-language policy are children with special needs, CBSE schools outside India, and foreign students returning to India. If guardians migrate to another State, the student may continue with the existing combination of languages.

Clarification for Class 9

The CBSE also provided examples to offer clarity for students in Class 9. For example, if a student already studies two Indian languages, for instance Hindi and Tamil, they can choose as third language another Indian language or



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and others during the release of DRDO Delegation of Financial Powers. PTI

Centre unveils plan to speed up DRDO's research projects

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday released the Delegation of Financial Powers to DRDO (DFP-2026), a major reform aimed at improving efficiency, accountability, and the timely execution of strategic research and development projects.

Speaking at the launch, Mr. Singh said the revised framework would facilitate faster production and induction of systems, platforms and technologies developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) into the armed forces.

He added that the DFP-2026 would strengthen collaboration with industry and academia,

further advancing the government's vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat.

‘Enhance self-reliance’
Mr. Singh said the new financial powers framework would enhance self-reliance in defence technologies and significantly strengthen the country's defence preparedness.

The revised framework provides dedicated financial provisions for trial campaigns, testing and evaluation activities, authorises the sanctioning of pre-project R&D initiatives, and clearly segregates financial powers for grants-in-aid related to Extra-Mural Research Projects, and Defence Innovation Accelerator-Centres of Excellence under separate schedules.

Passport issues faced by two journalists a concern: PCI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Press Club of India on Monday expressed concern over passport-related issues faced by two senior journalists, including former Editor of *The Telegraph* R. Rajagopal, whose name was deleted from the voters' list of West Bengal.

“If a respected senior editor like Mr. Rajagopal is facing difficulties to prove his citizenship in the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, what hardships lakhs of ordinary citizens must be enduring through that process is a significant question that emerges from this instance,” it said. The PCI said the passport of another senior journalist, Samrat Choudhury, was impounded earlier this month citing an “adverse” police verification report.

Man held for giving out poison capsules at Muharram rally

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Mumbai Police have arrested a 39-year-old man for allegedly distributing capsules containing the rodent poison zinc phosphide to participants in a Muharram procession.

The suspect has been identified as Faiyaz Nisar Premji, a resident of Pune. The police have seized 14,900 capsules and 50 kg of the chemical compound from his possession.

According to the police, the arrest was made on Friday night during the Ashura procession in the Byculla area. Officers allegedly spotted Mr. Premji distributing capsules to members of the crowd. When questioned, he claimed that the capsules were painkillers. However, as he could not produce any authorisation for their dis-

The police have seized 14,900 capsules and 50 kg of the chemical compound

tribution and reports later emerged of people experiencing nausea and vomiting after consuming them, he was detained.

“During questioning, the accused confessed that he aimed to target specific people and cause them harm. The accused had ordered 30,000 empty capsules online. He also ordered 50 kg of zinc phosphide. He prepared the capsules by filling each one with one gram of zinc phosphide,” Jayant Meena, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), Zone 3, said.

The officer said Mr. Premji had visited Iran and Iraq in 2025.

Why are States opposing VB-G RAM G

EXPLAINER

Sobhana K. Nair

On July 1, the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) will become operational, replacing the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA). The Union Rural Development Ministry notified the draft rules for the new employment scheme on May 22, giving a month to stakeholders to submit their feedback.

The difference

The VB-G RAM G marks a shift from a “demand-driven framework” to a “supply-driven scheme”. Under the new system, allocations will be capped within a fixed budget determined by the Union government based on “objective parameters”.

While the new Act increases the number of guaranteed workdays from

100 to 125, it also significantly raises the financial burden on States from the current 10% share to 40% of total expenditure. Under the MGNREGA, the Union government was responsible for 100% of the labour wages and 75% of the material wages. In practice, this translated to a 90:10 cost share between the Centre and the States.

Section 5(l) empowers the Union government to “notify rural areas in a State” where the scheme will be implemented. This is a departure from the MGNREGA, which was universal. Another departure from the MGNREGA is that the new law allows for a blackout period, pausing the programme during peak agricultural seasons to “facilitate availability of labour”.

Objections by the States

At least three States – Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, and Jharkhand, two of them with BJP-led governments – questioned the shift in



At least three States have raised questions about the shift in the financial model of VB-G RAM G.

the financial model, which now requires a majority of States to bear 40% of the total expenditure, in contrast to the MGNREGA.

Five States have sought a revision of wage rates, and four have aired reservations over the provision of 60 non-working days during the peak agricultural season.

Bihar has sought that wages should increase from the present ₹255 to ₹413. Jammu & Kashmir, meanwhile, wants an in-

crease in wages from ₹272 to ₹311. Both Jharkhand and Punjab argued that wages should be competitive and in line with market conditions. Uttarakhand underlined the tough landscape that workers have to work on and sought a compensatory hike. Nearly all States have highlighted delays in clearing the wage and material bill by the Centre.

Centre to hold power

One of the key concerns raised by academics and activists is that the VB-G RAM G gives disproportionate power to the Centre. As per the draft rules on inter-State distribution of funds, the Union government will adopt objective parameters utilised for horizontal devolution among States as recommended by the 16th Finance Commission. The exact application methodology is determined at the discretion of the Union government, a clause, flagged as concerning.

New rural jobs Act is not fair, CPI(M) leader tells Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The “objective parameters” for the fund allocation under the VB-G RAM G are neither “objective nor fair” and the new rural employment law relies excessively on technology and lays out no parameters for wage fixation, senior CPI (M) leader Brinda Karat wrote in a letter to Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Monday.

The rules, Ms. Karat said, were notified without any consultation with workers' organisations or unions and strengthened the Centre's control in decision-making.

The rule deciding the normative allocation, she said, sets up a framework of “rank discrimination” against workers depending on where they reside.

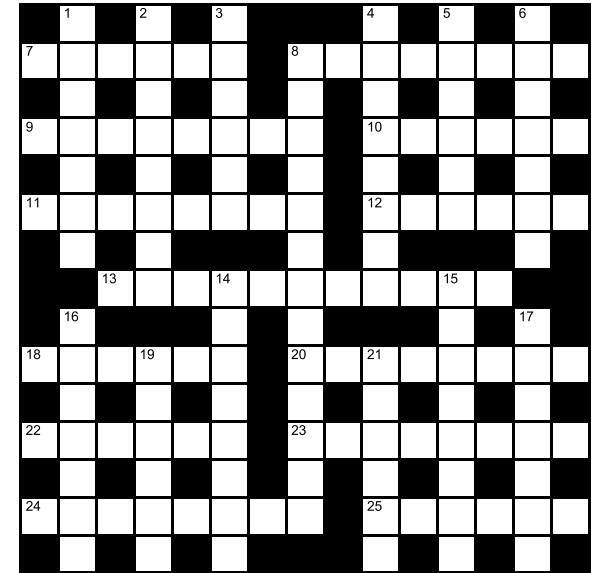


14833

(set by Pixie Dust)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at
<https://thehindu.com/crosswords>





- Across**
- 7 Protagonist nicked addictive substance (6)
- 8 To begin with wonderful, obviously original display - warm, opulently rich Kashmiri-style carpentry (8)
- 9 Bill breaking free of compulsive behaviours and expressions (8)
- 10 Declares: "Pixie Dust dividing shell money!" (6)
- 11 Fictional miser losing love for a French bum (8)

- 12 To a certain extent felt sensually repelled in snuggle (6)
- 13 The 'MACS' repeatedly played tournaments? (4,7)
- 18 Fictional detective's biographer, as per reports questioned boy (6)
- 20 Vision I quote in conversation (8)
- 22 Some misread her enchantment for Bond (6)
- 23 Can this masquerader redesign a crimson top? (8)
- 24 Authentic, clear garlic soup without traces of olives and parsley (8)
- 25 Blue-collar worker from Colombo will binge every now and then (6)
- Down**
- 1 Spooner says: "The rest and I talk behind their back entrance!" (7)
- 2 Open spot? Perhaps take a rain check! (8)
- 3 Native of Banjarmasin, Borneo (6)
- 4 Stuck-up Dominic in a clover, exposed and dangerous (8)
- 5 Hits outside net essentially and panics (6)
- 6 Member cycling around strange black object (7)
- 8 Let Maria refuse! (5,8)
- 14 Drive nurse to Easthampton on vacation with Charlie Yen (8)
- 15 Release young girl endlessly overwhelmed by mounting racket (8)
- 16 Honesty from John Grim (7)
- 17 Deranged gossip about Oscar I see in texting (7)
- 19 Delivered butcher's toboggan (6)
- 21 Imagine master having no right adopting canine (6)

SUDOKU

		7		3	6			
				7			1	4
		5			4		2	
		6	7	4	8			
1								2
				5	2	1	9	
	2		3			1		
3	6			1				
			6	8		4		

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle	Solution to yesterday's Sudoku
ETHNIC PHARMACY IGNORANT PARENT H S N C I I D STRENGTHEN GALE E E E O E ANTLERED SOLEMN O I T E D A FRAMES OBTUSEST THE O F R THUS UNFRIENDLY E I T E L O E FAVOUR RELATIVE S N T E E E STRESSED DESIRE	4 5 7 3 6 8 9 1 2 1 3 6 7 9 2 8 5 4 9 2 8 5 4 1 6 3 7 7 8 9 1 5 3 2 4 6 3 1 4 2 8 6 5 7 9 5 6 2 9 7 4 1 8 3 6 7 1 4 2 5 3 9 8 2 4 3 8 1 9 7 6 5 8 9 5 6 3 7 4 2 1

FAITH

Mooka Panchasati benefits

There are only two things worth aspiring for in life. One is to be born as a human and having born thus, pray to God for liberation (*mukshatvam*) from worldly attachments and rebirth. The advantage a human has over other life forms is the quality of discernment, and this should be channelised in proper manner. Man has the ability to know what is permanent in this universe and should aim to achieve that in his life. Our sastras show the way forward, and reciting verses from works such as Mooka Panchasati will help one, said Damodara Deekshithar.

Scriptures state that there are seven places which are so holy that staying in those places for a short while and focusing on the Divine will help one attain moksha. These are Ayodhya, Mathura, Maya (Haridwar), Kasi, Kanchi, Avantika (Ujjain) and Dwaraka. Kanchi, meaning central part, is one of the holiest places to reside, since it is Ambal's favourite place. One may conduct yagas, perform pujas and be a close adherent to dharma, but nothing comes close to receiving the grace of Kanchi Kamakoti.

Mooka Sankarendra Saraswati, the 20th Pontiff of Kanchi Kamakoti Peetam, composed Mooka Panchasati, after receiving Her grace. Born deaf mute, he visited Ambal's temple every day, attending the prayer rituals and partaking *prasad*. Such is the power of prayer, that Ambal, moved by the faith, is ready to offer Her blessings to true devotees. Like Kalidasa receiving the blessings of Kali, Mooka in Kanchi received similar benediction. His 500-verse composition, Mooka Panchasati remains relevant, the reading of which is believed to offer relief from various ailments.

Business

INBRIEF



Apple accuses India of 'copy-pasting' rivals in probe

Apple has accused the Competition Commission of India of “copy-pasting” its rivals’ claims and failing to properly conduct its own investigation in concluding the U.S. tech giant breached competition laws, calling for the findings to be quashed, regulatory papers reviewed by *Reuters* showed. The June 25 Apple submission, being reported for the first time, marks the sharpest escalation yet in Apple’s fight with the CCI, where Tinder-owner Match and Indian start-ups are among its opponents. In 2024, CCI investigators privately issued a report saying Apple engaged in “abusive conduct” on the apps platform of its iOS operating system, and wrongly mandated the use of its payment system.

Centre eases metrology rules for first-time violators

The Department of Consumer Affairs on Monday said it has introduced an “Improvement Notice” mechanism under the Legal Metrology Act, 2009, allowing businesses to rectify first-time procedural non-compliances before facing penal action. The change has been effected through the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026, as part of the government’s Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) agenda. A Legal Metrology Officer detecting a specified first-time procedural or regulatory lapse may issue an Improvement Notice, identifying the deficiency and providing reasonable time to correct it. PTI

Tech Mahindra to deploy Perplexity AI platform

Tech Mahindra on Monday said it will deploy AI platform Perplexity across its sales and customer-facing teams for better client engagement. The integration of ‘Perplexity Enterprise Pro’ aims to equip senior sales leaders and customer partners with intelligent tools to research customer priorities efficiently, understand industry-specific challenges and identify emerging business opportunities, the company said. Equipping sales teams with intelligent tools that support faster decision-making and deeper customer understanding will improve sales performance while delivering more personalised and meaningful experiences for customers, it said. PTI

AI must not compromise data integrity: Mishra

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Even as India moves towards AI-ready datasets, such data can become an asset to the country “only when backed by robust standards of quality, privacy and transparency”, P. K. Mishra, Principal Secretary to the PM said on Monday.

Speaking at the 20th Statistics Day, Mr. Mishra said that while Artificial Intelligence (AI) offers “transformative opportunities” for statistical analysis and policymaking, its adoption must be guided by strong governance frameworks to address bias, accountability and explainability.

Datasets updated

Mr. Mishra acknowledged after decades of excellence, the statistical system faced challenges relating to outdated datasets, delays in data dissemination, fragmented statistical architecture and declining professional capacity.

“The concerns prompted a comprehensive reform exercise led by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) through extensive consultations with experts and stakeholders,” Mr. Mishra said. “Based on the deliberations, MoSPI accepted 216 recommendations for time-bound im-



P. K. Mishra

plementation under an institutional oversight mechanism.”

He highlighted the reforms had already led to the introduction of new and user demand-based surveys, updating of macroeconomic indicators, improved data dissemination and significant procedural and process-oriented reforms.

Since February, the government had released updated series of national accounts, Index of Industrial Production, Consumer Price Index and Wholesale Price Index apart from introducing Producer Price Index and the Index of Services Production.

On India’s adoption of AI-ready datasets, he said: “Administrative data can become a powerful national asset only when backed by robust standards of quality, privacy and transparency.”

Only electric two-wheelers to ply on Delhi roads from 2028

Territorial government notifies new EV policy that mandates all two-wheelers to shift to EVs from April 1, 2028; only electric three-wheelers and NI trucks to be registered from January 1, 2027

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Notifying its new EV policy on Monday, the Delhi government said that it would focus entirely on electric vehicles, and that no subsidies would be provided for hybrid vehicles. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that the Cabinet had approved the policy at a ₹7,000 crore budget with an overall investment of ₹15,000 crore, including for development of charging infrastructure, purchase and scrapping incentives.

The territorial government has also put into place deadlines for various categories of vehicles to be transitioned to EVs. From January 1, 2027, only electric three wheelers and NI trucks will be registered. The deadline for two-wheelers to shift to EV is April 1, 2028. School buses would also need to convert at least 10% of their fleet to EV within two years of notification of the policy.

Calling the policy ‘transformative and revolutionary’, the CM said that the transition would be instrumental in combatting air pollution in the city. Ms. Gupta said that the new policy was likely to come into effect on July 1, 2026, and would remain effective till March 31, 2030.

The transport department will be the nodal



No entry: Transport Secretary Niharika Rai claimed 46% of air pollution was caused by by two- and three-wheelers. FILE PHOTO

agency for the implementation of the policy with Delhi Transco Ltd. (DTL) responsible for developing charging infrastructure in the city, including collaborating with the power department and distribution companies to provide power for the EV transition.

Transport Secretary Niharika Rai said that 33% of air pollution was caused by commercial goods carrier vehicles and 46% by two- and three-wheelers. “The policy focuses on these vehicles specifically. We are trying to convert the entire fleet of these vehicles into EV,” she said.

The government has allocated a budget of ₹7,000 crore for implementation of the policy with an additional ₹3,000 crore as purchase and scrapping incentives. About ₹1,000 crore has been allocated for development of charging infrastructure in the city. Besides, citizens would also be exempted from road tax

and registration fee would be waived for all electric vehicles (EVs). The government was expected to lose ₹3,000 crore worth of revenue from these benefits, the officials said.

However, the officials specified that the road tax and registration fee exemption would be applicable for cars costing only up to ₹30 lakh, at ex-show-room price.

The official said that citizens would get purchase incentives of up to ₹30,000 for two-wheelers: ₹30,000 in the first year of notification of the policy, ₹20,000 in the second year and ₹10,000 in the third year. For three wheelers, the incentives will be ₹50,000, ₹40,000 and ₹30,000 respectively, for the first, second and third years. Similarly, a subsidy of up to ₹1 lakh would be provided for NI commercial trucks in the first year of the EV policy.

Scrapping incentives for

vehicles below BS-IV emission norms categories would be around ₹10,000 for two-wheelers, ₹25,000 for three-wheelers and ₹1 lakh for four-wheelers. Scrapping NI trucks would beget ₹50,000 as incentive and Gramin Seva units completing their lifecycle in the coming years, would also get ₹15,000 subsidy, the officials said.

Moreover, electric N2 trucks, i.e., those carrying loads from 3.5-12 tonnes, would be exempted from ‘No Entry’ timings for the next 10 years. However, this is applicable only to the first 1,000 N2 trucks purchased within three months of notification of the policy.

The officials also said that no subsidy would be provided for hybrid vehicles. A new dedicated EV portal would keep track of purchased and registered vehicles for which consumers would have to submit their documents to avail subsidies and incentives.

Consumers would be able to apply for the subsidies within 30 days of issuance of registration certificates. The subsidies would be provided within 60 days through DBT.

The government also plans to install 32,000 charging points infrastructure within the next four years, funded by PM e-Drive schemes as well as the Delhi government budget.

Union Cabinet okays ₹30,000 cr. additional investment in NIIF for new fund creation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet has approved an additional investment by the Government of India of ₹30,000 crore in the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) to be used for its upcoming funds, the government announced on Monday.

The decision itself was taken last week, it said. This would take the government’s total commitment in NIIF to ₹60,000 crore. The NIIF is India’s sovereign anchored fund, in which the government of India is a 49% shareholder. It currently manages capital commitments of about ₹40,000 crore across its funds and investment strategies, the government said.

“We are grateful for this allocation of ₹30,000 crore, which is a strong reaffirmation of Government support to NIIF and reinforces the catalytic capital model that has defined NIIF since inception,” Sanjiv Aggarwal, Managing Director and CEO of NIIF said.

New fund

According to a release by NIIF, this additional allocation from the government will help NIIF raise larger funds, attract investors across geographies, and deepen its presence in key sectors of the economy.



This additional investment of ₹30,000 crore will be used to set up NIIF’s second infrastructure focussed fund, the successor to its first flagship fund with this mandate

The government said that this additional investment of ₹30,000 crore will be used to set up NIIF’s second infrastructure focussed fund, the successor to its first flagship fund with this mandate.

“NIIF Infrastructure Fund II is proposed to have a target corpus of close to ₹30,000 crore and is expected to undertake investments across transportation, energy, digital infrastructure, and emerging areas such as urban infrastructure and e-mobility,” the government release said.

It added that the allocation will also support NIIF’s new fund strategies and upcoming bilateral and strategic funds.

“Over the past decade, GoI’s anchor commitment has enabled us to build a very strong institutional investor base, spanning leading sovereign wealth funds, pension funds, multilateral and bilateral institutions, and domestic financial institutions,” Mr. Aggarwal added.

FPIs pour in a record ₹53,300 cr. to compensate for debt equity exit

Ashokamithran T
MUMBAI

Foreign Institutional Investors (FII) poured a record ₹53,363 crore in all types of debt securities to compensate for a near equal amount sold in equities in

June 2026. This led to a net inflow of about ₹334 crore in all instruments, according to data from NSDL.

Debt security investments are classified into General Limit, Voluntary Retention Route (VRR) and Fully Accessible Route

(FAR) – a large section of which could be attributed to government securities.

Inflows in the General Limit and Fully Accessible Route (FAR) came in at ₹28,196 and ₹21,788 crore in June 2026. FAR bond investments were up five

times and General Limit investments increased from an outflow of ₹100 crore last month. The increase in inflows comes weeks after the Ministry of Finance exempted government securities from long-term capital gains and increased the te-

nors of bonds in the FAR category in a bid to deepen bond markets. The move also comes at a time when the overall foreign investor behaviour leans towards aversion to the Indian markets, largely due to sub-par returns in equities owing

to higher valuations and a depreciated rupee. Equity outflow, however, continued for the fourth consecutive month to ₹51,456 crore in June 2026. In the past six months put together, equity outflows alone were ₹2.76 lakh crore.

इण्डियन ओवरसीज़ बैंक
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Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, Anna Salai, Chennai-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - SELECTION OF COLOCATION DATA CENTRE SERVICE PROVIDER FOR BANK'S DISASTER RECOVERY DATA CENTRE SITE ON CO-HOSTING MODEL

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7708010 DATED 24.06.2026

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites **www.iob.bank.in** & **www.gem.gov.in** For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website **www.gem.gov.in**

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work:

Tender No. T25P111924: Design, Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of 33 KV GIS with complete civil works at various 220 kV Substation of DTL on turnkey basis. (IP, Parkstreet, Wazirpur, Naraina & Okhla)

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :-
https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_294402_1) and **www.dtl.gov.in** with Unique No. DTL-0063-250626.

Last date for bid submission: **14.08.2026 at 01.30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/ Date of Extension/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, P.W.D., CIRCLE-JHALAWAR

Room No. - 158, Ground Floor (Public Works Department), Mini Secretariat, Jhalawar

E-mail :- piu.jhalawar@rediffmail.com/scjwara.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

Phone No. :- 07432-233336

S. No. :- 357

Date :- 19-06-2026

NIT No. 12/2026-27

Notice Inviting Bid

NIB No. PWD2627A1296

Bids for 12 Nos CD Works in Jhalrapatan Constituency in Distt. Jhalawar & Const. of Road from Lasudiya shah to Gokulpura & 21 Nos. ML Roads in Jhalrapatan Constituency Distt. Jhalawar are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM, Dated 20.07.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://erproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the Rajasthan and <http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in> website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 5568.75 Lacs.

S. No.	UBN No.	S. No.	UBN No.	S. No.	UBN No.
1	PWD2627WSOB05500	2	PWD2627WSOB05501	3	PWD2627WSOB05504
4	PWD2627WSOB05506	5	PWD2627WSOB05507	6	PWD2627WSOB05508
7	PWD2627WSOB05509	8	PWD2627WSOB05510	9	PWD2627WSOB05511
10	PWD2627WSOB05512	11	PWD2627WSOB05513	12	PWD2627WSOB05514
13	PWD2627WSOB05515	14	PWD2627WSOB05516	15	PWD2627WSOB05517
16	PWD2627WSOB05518	17	PWD2627WSOB05519	18	PWD2627WSOB05520
19	PWD2627WSOB05521	20	PWD2627WSOB05522	21	PWD2627WSOB05523
22	PWD2627WSOB05524	23	PWD2627WSOB05525	24	PWD2627WSOB05526
25	PWD2627WSOB05527	26	PWD2627WSOB05528	27	PWD2627WSOB05530

(Mukesh Chand Meena)

Superintending Engineer

Public Works Department

Circle-Jhalawar

DIPR/C/11246/2026

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- Digital Transformation
- Financial Transformation
- Social Transformation
- Changemaker of the Year

A CH-CH

Eustaquio's late strike earns Canada a spot in the last 16



Broos may reverse decision to quit as South Africa coach



Saudi football federation chief stands down after team's exit



India wins maiden gold at the World Rowing Cup in Switzerland



Martinelli's last-gasp goal takes Brazil past Japan into the pre-quarterfinals

Refreshed Norway faces Ivory Coast



New Zealand wraps up series with emphatic win

Stokes leaves the international arena with the aura of a miracle-worker

Stokes' Test numbers

BATTING	M	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg	100s/50s
	122	220	7273	258	34.46	14/37
BOWLING	M	Inns	Wkts	BBI	SR	5WI/10WM
	122	182	252	6/22	55.8	6/0

Stokes leaves with an aura even if his sporting twilight was dull.

When nostalgia draws Botham into conversations, Stokes would not be far and that is a splendid achievement.



Govt. of Uttarakhand



GAURAV, VIKAS AUR SANKALP KA PARV



Devbhoomi
Uttarakhand

VIKAS BHI, VIRASAT BHI



"The Honorable Prime Minister has called the third decade of the 21st century the decade of Uttarakhand. In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with an uncompromised resolve a 'Vikalp Rahit Sankalp' to make the state an exemplary state in every field."

PUSHKAR SINGH DHAMI, Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

"There are two major pillars in building the developed India of the 21st century. First, taking pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both of these pillars. This decade is Uttarakhand's decade."

NARENDRA MODI, Prime Minister

Foundation Stone Laid for Iconic Ropeway Projects

The foundation stone has been laid for the construction of ropeways from Gaurikund to Kedarnath and Govindghat to Hemkund Sahib. "The 12.9 km ropeway from Sonprayag to Kedarnath will be constructed at a cost of ₹4,081 crore, while the 12.4 km ropeway from Govindghat to Hemkund Sahib will be built at a cost of ₹2,730 crore.

Expansion of Air Services

An additional terminal has been constructed at the Dehradun Airport. Regular flight services have commenced from Dehradun Airport to major Indian cities, including Ahmedabad, Bhubaneswar, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Kolkata, Delhi, Shamshabad, Jaipur, Lucknow, Pune, and Kullu.

Agricultural & Industrial Development

The Central Government has sanctioned a fund of ₹25 crore for farm fencing in the state. The Central Government has transferred 45.33 of land belonging to the HMT Factory in Haldwani (Ranibagh) to the Government of Uttarakhand.

Roads and Corridors

Approval has been granted for the construction of the proposed Rispana and Bindal Elevated Corridor projects to alleviate growing traffic congestion in Dehradun city. The Prime Minister dedicated to the nation the 210 km long Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor, built at a cost of ₹11,963 crore. The Central Government has approved ₹1,105 crore for the construction of the 12.67 km long, 4-lane Rishikesh Bypass.

Railway Expansion

Uttarakhand welcomes two Vande Bharat Express trains, making travel from Dehradun to Delhi and Dehradun to Lucknow highly convenient. "Train operations have been approved for routes connecting Lalkuan to Amritsar Junction, and Dehradun to Tanakpur. Construction of the Rishikesh - Karnaprayag rail line is progressing rapidly, with 72.5% of the work already completed. Approval has been granted for the survey of the Tanakpur- Bageshwar rail route; work on the project's Detailed Project Report (DPR) is underway at a swift pace.

NEW DIMENSIONS OF DEVELOPMENT

Development Initiatives Dedicated to Nation Building



Uttarakhand allocated ₹4,769 crore under the Rail Budget in the Union Budget 2026-27.

The chardham shrines have been connected with an all-weather road built at a cost of over ₹12,000 crore, making travel across the mountains smooth and hassle-free.

Uttarakhand secured the first position among small states in the Export Preparedness Index 2024 released by NITI Aayog.

The Jamrani Dam project received approval from the Central Government. To be constructed at a cost of ₹3,678.23 crore, the project is slated for completion by June 2029.

To economically empower women, more than 2 lakh 54 thousand women in the state have successfully become 'Lakhpati Didis'.

A dedicated Rafting Base Station will be built in Rishikesh, for which the Central Government has sanctioned ₹100 crore.

The National Games were hosted in the state for the very first time.

When we come from our hometowns to Devbhoomi for the Chardham Yatra, we do so with a resolve in our hearts. In the same spirit, I would also like to urge you to take five resolves: Narendra Modi

First Resolve : Cleanliness is paramount.

Second Resolve : Sensitivity toward nature and the environment.

Third Resolve : Emphasis on service, cooperation, & unity.

Fourth Resolve : Promotion of 'Vocal for Local'.

Fifth Resolve : Adherence to discipline, safety, & decorum.





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- ▶ Neurology
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R. Kaushik

India's first Twenty20 International outing after lifting the 2024 T20 World Cup in the Americas ended in a crushing defeat to an unfancied opponent. History repeated itself last week as they courted a similar result in their first fixture after successfully defending the world crown at home this March.

Nearly two years earlier, in July, a second-string outfit led by Shubman Gill went down by 13 runs to Sikandar Raza's team at the Harare Sports Club. Fear not, said the intrepid bunch; Abhishek Sharma made up for a four-ball duck on debut with a stunning century in game two, the catalyst for what in the end was a commanding 4-1 score line that reiterated that defeat in game one was an aberration.

Worst imaginable start

Last Friday, India surrendered their unbeaten record against Ireland in the most unedifying of manners, slumping to a 34-run humbling in Belfast. It was the worst imaginable start to Shreyas Iyer's new avatar as India's T20I captain, a comedown from the highs of the IPL for stars weaned on terrific batting strips. The conditions at the Civil Service Cricket Club in Stormont were demanding, arduous, anything but ideal for unfettered ball-striking. India were found desperately wanting despite being at full strength from a batting perspective as a target of 183 proved well beyond them.

It happens, everyone said. You can sometimes be fixed by alien conditions. The opposition is allowed one terrific game, you are allowed one poor day in office, especially because as a team, the Indians had gathered together for the first time in more than three and a half months. Not an excuse, because Ireland outplayed them, but you could see some rationale behind what was indisputably a horror outcome.

But *a la* Harare and 2024, there were no comebacks this time. India conceded Sunday's second T20I too, admittedly by only a solitary run, as a proud record came to a juddering halt. An unbeaten streak encompassing 16 series spread over three years in the most unpredictable and unforgiving of formats was snapped ruthlessly by an honest Irish side that made capital of its familiarity with the conditions, though more than anyone else, one suspects, the Irish themselves would have been surprised at home tamely India's famed batting line-up capitulated.

Ryan ten Doeschate, India's refreshingly honest and forthcoming assistant coach, spoke of 'disbelief' within the camp after Sunday's tense finish. He stressed the need to adapt, and adapt quickly, when the team travels to Europe and to other parts of the world where seam can be a major factor. He pointed to the smarts the Irish displayed, silently bemoaning the lack of the same from his wards.

This was supposed to be the teasing appetiser before the sumptuous main course, which will unfold on Wednesday when India lock horns with England in the first of five T20Is. But the appetiser has left a bitter taste in the mouth and left Gautam Gambhir, the beleaguered head coach, with a fresh headache that he must find a solution to in double quick time.

Gambhir has overseen three excellent white-ball title-winning runs - at the Champions Trophy in March 2025 and the T20 Asia Cup that same September, both in Dubai, and at the home T20 World Cup earlier this year. But he has also been the central figure in unprecedented Test series routs at home against New Zealand in late 2024 and South Africa 12 months thereafter. When it comes to the Test squad, he alternates between the word 'transition' and 'inexperience'. He bristles at players only eight and ten Tests young being (unfairly) judged and bares his fangs at the slightest perception of criticism. But the numbers are stacking up against him. And cricket, more than any other sport, is a game of numbers.

Between the two T20 World Cups in 2024 and 2026, India lost just six out of 41 matches, a grand result considering that like now, they had a new captain. Rohit Sharma's retirement after the 2024 edition ushered Suryakumar Yadav into the job; the axe falling on the latter despite him leading his unit to the 2026 crown has thrust Shreyas into the hot seat. It will be unfair, to borrow from Gambhir, to judge the youngest of the trio of Mumbaiers to have led the T20I side in the last few years on the back of just one series, and that too given that India had very little time to get used to environs that they are reasonably unfamiliar with. But Shreyas will be mindful that he himself managed just 3 and 10 on his comeback to the T20I mix, and that will hurt him immensely because he is a firm believer in the 'leading from the front' philosophy.

Let's not grudge Ireland their moment of unmatched glory. They have produced stunning upsets, not least at the 2011



Supermen: Hollard and Moondra combined to torment the India batters and script an incredible series win for Ireland. The latter castled Samson (below) off the first ball he bowled in the opening T20I. GETTY IMAGES

50-over World Cup when a magical century from Kevin O'Brien pulled the rug from under England's feet in Bengaluru. But this will take precedence, one suspects, even though it came in what was a regular bilateral series - inasmuch as any series involving India can be termed 'regular'.

They were blithely expected to be lambs to the slaughter, to roll over without much resistance. But we should have known better. Ireland don't surrender, they don't throw in the towel. They are spirited, sure, but they are also very skilful and supremely self-confident. They leave nothing behind in the change room, and win or lose, they are content when they know that they have given it their all.

This time, their 'all' translated to an epochal 2-0 sweep against the World Cup winners and the No. 1 team in the world which had all its batting guns to fall back on, and with one of the most destructive modern-day weapons watching on from the dugout.

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi needs no introduction, not anymore, not after his spectacular deeds at the Under-19 World Cup and in the IPL and during the triangular 'A' series in Sri Lanka. At 15, he is already making heads turn, forcing people to reach for their remotes when he takes guard, delighting his millions of fans and sending chills and shivers down the spines of the most celebrated active bowlers in world cricket. The temptation to unleash this man-child beast must be immense, but ten Doeschate was emphatic in stating that like everyone else, the precociously unique talent must go through the processes and bide his time. That there will be no special treatment, no matter how special he is.

Learning process

That's part of the learning process, the growing-up stage, though with each passing failure for Sanju Samson or Ishan Kishan or both - two of the more influential cogs during the World Cup campaign, Samson the more feted for match-winning knocks in the last three matches but Kishan no less impactful - the clamour for Sooryavanshi's much awaited debut will gather pace.

Let's just hit the pause button and remember that he is 15. Fifteen. That he should not be - never mind that he is yet to make his maiden appearance - expected to carry the Indian batting on his strong and sturdy but very, very young shoulders. Let's not transpose our expectations onto him, let's not compare him with Sachin Tendulkar because hey,

Gambhir has overseen three excellent white-ball title-winning runs - at the Champions Trophy in March 2025 and the T20 Asia Cup the same September, both in Dubai, and at the home T20 World Cup earlier this year

how silly is that? The teen phenom will be desperate to make his first India appearance - which cricketer worth his salt wouldn't? - not so much because it will be another feather in his already overcrowded cap but because he genuinely loves playing and putting on a show. But he will learn the virtues of patience and being treated as just another player, which should stand him in grand stead in the long run.

Chastened by the Ireland humbling orchestrated by a software engineer from our own Tonk in Rajasthan, India will know the magnitude of the task that awaits them in England. Jai Moondra, a strapping 29-year-old who moved to Dublin in 2021 to pursue a master's degree in electronics and communication, still holds an Indian passport but did the country of his birth no favours, exposing an old Indian kryptonite - left-arm pace. Five wickets in his first two appearances for his adopted country, and the Player of the Series honours, is a high Moondra will soar on, deservedly and understandably, for a long time to come.

India will have arrived in England on Monday to blaring headlines about Ben Stokes' dramatic, sudden but almost inevitable retirement from international cricket following his latest dalliance with infamy. Stokes' announcement was the most visceral on a Sunday of high-octane cricketing entertainment in the British Isles. The Indian men's loss to Ireland came around the same time that the women were eliminated from the T20 World Cup after going down to Australia in their must-win final league tie at Lord's. Over in Nottingham, around the Stokes headline act, England and New Zealand were in a pitched battle for series honours and World Test Championship points.

India's most recent 20-over skirmish with England itself was not devoid of thrills and tension and agony and ecstasy. A total of 253 in the World Cup semifinal in Mumbai in March seemed inadequate when Jacob Bethell put on an exhibition, simultaneously sparking awe and dread among Indian spectators. India needed the genius of Jasprit Bumrah to come away unscathed, by the hair-raising

margin of just seven runs, but there is no Bumrah now - rested - and therefore it will be incumbent on the rest of the bowlers to step up.

The returning Harshit Rana showcased his combativeness in Ireland and Prince Yadav was impressive on his debut, suggesting that with Arshdeep Singh now in the role of the lead enforcer, the pace bowling is in pretty good hands. It's the lack of batting form that will trouble Shreyas, Gambhir and the rest of the leadership group.

Against singularly attack-minded teams like England, India have historically relied on their batting strength to bail them out. Now, that strength has become a temporary weakness. What corrective measures are put in place in a very straitjacketed time-frame remains to be seen. But these measures are imperative because otherwise, Harry Brook and embattled coach Brendon McCullum's England, themselves feeling no little heat, will feast on them with ill-concealed glee.



THE GIST

Ireland don't surrender, they don't throw in the towel. They are spirited, sure, but they are also very skilful and supremely self-confident

Chastened by the Ireland humbling orchestrated by a software engineer from our own Tonk in Rajasthan, India will know the magnitude of the task that awaits them in England

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Outlay of clean technology scheme for steel sector

5,000 in ₹ crore. The Centre is planning to introduce a scheme to promote the adoption of clean technologies in steelmaking processes. The scheme named National Strategy for Sustainable Secondary Steel is expected to be launched in the next three months. PTI

Number of civilians in Afghanistan killed by Pakistan airstrikes

36 Overnight airstrikes by Pakistani forces have killed at least 36 civilians and injured more than 160 others, Afghan officials said on Monday. Hundreds of people have been killed in cross-border fighting since February, when Afghanistan launched retaliatory strikes after Pakistan carried out airstrikes inside Afghan territory. PTI

BLOs conducting special intensive revision in Delhi

13,000 The special intensive revision (SIR) of Delhi's electoral rolls will begin on Tuesday, with over 13,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) undertaking a door-to-door verification exercise, Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Ashok Kumar said on Monday. PTI

Japanese entities on which China imposed export controls

40 China imposed new export controls Monday on 40 Japanese entities it says are contributing to the country's "remilitarisation," as tensions with Tokyo continue to rise. Twenty entities have been placed on a control list, which prohibits Chinese and foreign exporters from selling to them dual-use items made in China. PTI

People in Europe facing temperatures above 35°C

130 in million. At least 130 million people in Europe, mainly located in the central and eastern parts of the continent, are set for temperatures exceeding 35 °C on Monday, according to AFP calculations. This is down from more than 191 million on Sunday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On the delay in India-U.S. trade deal

India and the U.S. announced in February 2025 that they would work towards a Bilateral Trade Agreement, but differences over agriculture and Russian oil, along with legal battles in Washington and investigations initiated by the Trump administration, have clouded its prospects

EXPLAINER

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far:

India and the U.S. in February 2025 announced that they would work towards a comprehensive Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) that was to be finalised by fall 2025. Then, in February 2026, they signed a framework agreement for an interim trade deal that was to be implemented by April-May 2026. Neither deal has come to pass.

Why was the BTA delayed?

Soon after Prime Minister Narendra Modi and U.S. President Donald Trump announced their intentions to complete a BTA in February 2025, it became clear that a comprehensive deal would be elusive. The talk among government officials was about finalising at least the first tranche of the deal by fall 2025 (September-November 2025).

Talks intensified post April 2025, after Mr. Trump first announced his 'Liberation Day' reciprocal tariffs and then paused them for 90 days so he could negotiate deals with U.S. trade partners. However, despite several meetings, India and the U.S. could not finalise the first tranche, with key sticking points being India's reluctance to open up its agricultural and dairy sectors, and its decision to buy oil from Russia.

In two successive announcements in late July and early August, Mr. Trump raised tariffs on imports from India to 25% and then to 50%, with the latter hike being a penalty for India's Russian oil imports. This decision froze negotiations for a few months before matters thawed once again and talks resumed in October.

What is the interim deal?

Once talks resumed, Mr. Modi and Mr. Trump in February 2026 signed a



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framework for an interim agreement on trade. This was not a trade deal itself, but the framework along which one could be worked out. At the time, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal expressed his confidence that the deal would be completed by April, or at the latest by early May 2026.

Under the framework, the U.S. was to reduce total tariffs on Indian imports to 18%, providing it a competitive advantage over its competitors. Both sides also committed to providing each other preferential market access in "sectors of respective interest".

Why has this deal been delayed?

Soon after the framework was announced, the U.S. Supreme Court invalidated the reciprocal tariff system itself, saying the law it was based on – the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) of the U.S. – did not allow for such tariffs. That removed a major foundation on which the deal negotiations had taken place.

Since then, the U.S. has taken several decisions that have further added to the tariff uncertainty.

Right after the Supreme Court's decision, Mr. Trump announced that he would be imposing a flat 10% tariff on imports from all countries under the Trade Act of 1974, which he said authorised him to take action to address the U.S.'s ballooning trade deficit. This tariff was temporary, supposed to last 150 days up to July 24. Mr. Trump said he would raise it to 15%, but never did.

The U.S. Court of International Trade deemed these illegal as well, but an appeals court put a stay on that order.

What fresh investigations have added more uncertainty?

In March, the office of the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) said it had initiated two investigations under Section 301 of the Trade Act into several of its trade partners that could potentially see further tariffs being imposed on them.

The first investigation against 16

economies, including India, was to see whether these economies were using excess manufacturing capacity to export to the U.S. in a manner that was hurting American businesses.

The second one, against 60 countries including India, was to look into whether these countries had taken "sufficient steps" to prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour and how the "failure to eradicate" these practices impacts U.S. workers and businesses.

Under the forced labour investigation, the U.S. government in early June proposed to levy a tariff of 12.5% on imports from 54 countries, including India, as they have "failed to impose and effectively enforce" prohibitions on the import of goods produced using forced labour. To be sure, this does not mean the U.S. is saying that India uses forced labour, but that it has not stopped the import of goods that have been manufactured using forced labour.

India has made its representations to the U.S. on this matter and the final hearing is on July 7. The findings of the excess capacity investigations are expected in mid-July.

What is India's stance on the deal?

As repeatedly expressed by Mr. Goyal, India remains committed to finalising a trade deal with the U.S. but is firm about the fact that it should receive a comparative advantage over its competitors as was agreed in February. For this, the Section 301 investigations will have to be completed and the tariffs decided on various countries.

In the meantime, the two sides continue to negotiate on the other non-tariff aspects of the deal, such as enhanced market access, digital trade, supply chain resilience, reduction of non-tariff barriers, and expanded cooperation in strategic sectors. The latest visit by USTR Jamieson Greer to India on June 23-24 did not yield any deadlines.

THE GIST

India and the U.S. missed both the planned 2025 Bilateral Trade Agreement and the 2026 interim deal after disagreements over agriculture, dairy and Russian oil imports, followed by shifting U.S. tariff policies and legal challenges that disrupted negotiations.

New U.S. Section 301 investigations into excess manufacturing capacity and forced-labour-related imports have delayed tariff decisions, while both sides continue negotiating non-tariff issues, with India insisting on a comparative tariff advantage before finalising the deal.

Has RBI changed the rules for scam compensation?

Who can claim compensation, how much can they receive, and what are the eligibility conditions?

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday issued fresh rules to protect customers from scam transactions where they lose money to fraudsters and cyberattacks. These directions amend the RBI's 2017 circular on "Limiting Liability of Customers in Unauthorised Electronic Banking Transactions". That previous framework only left banks liable to compensate scammed customers if transactions were not even authorised by customers, such as in a successful hacking incident. These rules are only a pilot for now, but may be extended in the future. They are effective from January 1, 2027, and last for the year.

What has the RBI changed?

In Wednesday's amendments, a draft version of which was released for public comment in March, customers can get reimbursed when they fall prey to certain scams, like digital arrests (where they are "coerced" into paying money), or when

one-time passcodes (OTPs) are "fraudulently" stolen from them. Most financial fraud currently relies on "social engineering" attacks, which require hoodwinking customers in one way or another; since banks' core cybersecurity infrastructure is heavily regulated and subject to RBI audits, "zero click" hacks are vanishingly rare.

The new key concept is "fraudulent electronic banking transactions (EBTs)". RBI defines these as transactions which are "executed by a third-party using the credentials obtained from the customer through fraudulent means or executed by the customer by granting approval under coercion or duress from the third-party" or "an EBT which is not authorised by a customer and inter alia includes an EBT occurring on account of negligence by a bank and/or a third-party breach."

This means that customers who ignore fraud signal warnings, such as those on a UPI PIN screen that a given transaction could be a scam, would not be eligible for any compensation. In cases of a third-party hack, the timeline for a customer to report the loss has been

increased to five calendar days from three working days. As in the 2017 rules, if any amount is deducted after a customer reports fraud, the customer bears no liability and is entitled to a reversal of the transaction.

Banks can waive customers' liability even if a transaction is negligent, but this is subject to their own discretion. If a user does not have their latest phone number or email address registered with the bank, this counts as negligence, as the bank would not send fraud alerts to the right contact.

How much compensation can customers receive?

For losses up to ₹50,000, individual victims can claim 85% of the amount as compensation, only once in their lifetime, up to ₹25,000. (This means that for any amount from ₹29,412 till ₹50,000, customers will receive a flat ₹25,000 compensation.) Roughly three-fourths of the amount will be paid by RBI itself, while the customer and beneficiary banks will pay half the remaining amount.

A customer must report to the

cybercrime helpline (1930) within five days to be eligible for this. It is worth noting that scams above ₹50,000 don't seem to be covered in this framework at all.

What changed between the draft and final rules?

From the March draft, banks have been given more time to implement this new system; the draft rules had a July 1 effective date. This is now January 1, 2027. Complaint settlement timelines are also now increased to 45-60 days, with the latter applying for international transactions.

Dvara Research, a non-profit financial inclusion think tank, had suggested that the vulnerability of customers be taken into account. "Research suggests that Indians encounter fraud attempts multiple times a week, that these attempts are growing more sophisticated, and therefore, it is not unlikely that customers may fall for them more than once," the body wrote.

"Vulnerable customers may not be expected to meet high standards of attentiveness or defend themselves against frauds that are sophisticated even for the more evolved customers ... Under the Indian Contract Act, contracts executed under information asymmetry, external influence, or fraudulent pretext are voidable... Bundling such different transactions under the common definition of 'authorised transaction' diminishes their fundamental difference and may even reduce the significance of a liability framework."

THE GIST

RBI's revised rules expand customer protection by allowing compensation for certain fraud caused by coercion or stolen credentials, not just unauthorised transactions.

Eligible customers can claim up to ₹25,000 for losses of up to ₹50,000 if they report the fraud within five days; the pilot framework takes effect from January 1, 2027.

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